

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	75.6
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	73.6
#3	A+	Oklahoma City	69.8
#4	A	Hartford	65.5
#5	A	Nashville	65.4
#6	A	Pittsburgh	64.3
#7	A	Richmond	63.2

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Sacramento	22.1
#49	D	Detroit	22.6
#48	C-	San Francisco	29.3
#47	C-	Orlando	30.9
#46	C-	San Diego	31.7
#45	C	San Jose	33.5
#44	C	Portland	35.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	21 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	2 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, LFP, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	75.6	3.0%	+4.5%	+1.2%	67.7%	60 days
2	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	73.6	3.4%	+3.1%	+1.8%	72.8%	49 days
3	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	A+	69.8	3.6%	+4.7%	+0.5%	65.7%	58 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.5	2.7%	-0.4%	+1.9%	64.7%	46 days
5	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	65.4	3.0%	+1.6%	+1.0%	76.3%	60 days
6	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A	64.3	3.6%	+8.7%	+1.1%	60.3%	90 days
7	Richmond Richmond	A	63.2	3.3%	+5.1%	+0.3%	64.2%	48 days
8	Birmingham Birmingham	A-	61.7	2.2%	-0.1%	+0.6%	60.6%	70 days
9	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A-	61.5	3.3%	+8.3%	-0.0%	64.6%	56 days
10	Columbus Columbus	A-	60.2	3.6%	+0.9%	+1.2%	65.6%	55 days
11	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	B+	58.1	3.2%	+3.2%	+0.7%	74.0%	76 days
12	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B+	57.5	3.6%	+6.6%	+0.1%	70.4%	38 days
13	Memphis Memphis	B+	56.6	4.0%	+6.2%	+0.1%	60.5%	79 days
14	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B+	55.9	N/A	+4.5%	+0.9%	66.3%	55 days
15	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B+	55.8	3.5%	+7.1%	+0.2%	62.5%	83 days
16	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	B+	55.5	2.5%	+5.1%	+0.1%	66.9%	73 days
17	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B+	55.2	4.0%	+2.2%	+1.2%	64.0%	53 days
18	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	53.6	3.6%	+3.1%	+0.3%	69.6%	57 days
19	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	52.5	4.8%	+5.3%	+1.8%	63.6%	44 days
20	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	51.5	4.2%	+2.6%	+0.4%	64.5%	54 days
21	Kansas City Kansas City	B	51.5	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.3%	67.9%	57 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
22	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B	51.3	3.7%	+1.8%	+1.1%	62.8%	79 days
23	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	B	50.2	3.1%	+3.4%	-0.1%	62.7%	50 days
24	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	48.7	4.5%	+4.8%	+0.5%	63.3%	68 days
25	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	48.4	3.9%	+1.4%	+0.7%	68.5%	42 days
26	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B-	48.3	3.6%	-1.5%	+2.7%	65.4%	69 days
27	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	46.9	4.6%	+4.9%	+0.9%	60.0%	80 days
28	Jacksonville Jacksonville	B-	46.5	4.6%	+5.0%	+0.7%	60.4%	72 days
29	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	46.0	5.0%	+7.6%	-0.1%	68.2%	36 days
30	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	B-	44.8	4.0%	+3.1%	+0.5%	63.9%	64 days
31	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	44.5	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.0%	65.3%	55 days
32	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	44.0	4.3%	+3.6%	+0.6%	50.8%	49 days
33	Cleveland Cleveland	C+	43.6	3.4%	-1.8%	+0.6%	58.0%	55 days
34	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	43.5	4.0%	+0.0%	+0.6%	69.0%	40 days
35	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	41.6	3.1%	+3.7%	-0.9%	63.2%	39 days
36	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	39.9	4.5%	+2.8%	+0.6%	64.8%	40 days
37	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	39.9	3.8%	+1.4%	-1.6%	67.4%	38 days
38	Fresno Fresno	C+	39.7	8.2%	+7.6%	+0.2%	60.3%	53 days
39	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	C+	38.8	5.2%	+6.7%	-0.8%	65.0%	53 days
40	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	38.6	3.6%	+10.2%	-1.3%	59.0%	40 days
41	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	38.5	3.6%	+1.2%	-0.1%	64.2%	45 days
42	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	36.4	5.1%	+7.5%	+0.2%	60.4%	60 days
43	Cincinnati Cincinnati	C	36.2	3.6%	+1.5%	-0.5%	63.1%	52 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	LFP	DOM
44	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.4	4.9%	+4.8%	-0.7%	66.2%	68 days
45	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	33.5	4.0%	+0.6%	-0.2%	64.3%	23 days
46	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C-	31.7	4.4%	+2.4%	+0.3%	62.0%	38 days
47	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C-	30.9	4.4%	+0.4%	+0.2%	64.0%	82 days
48	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C-	29.3	4.1%	+0.5%	-0.5%	64.5%	30 days
49	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	22.6	4.7%	-1.1%	+0.0%	61.3%	56 days
50	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	D	22.1	4.8%	+2.5%	-0.3%	60.1%	41 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

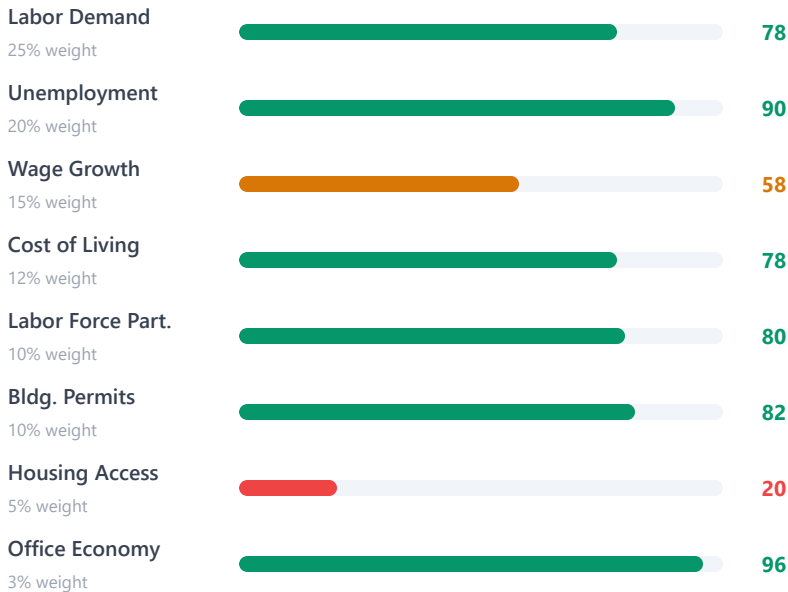
A+

EXCELLENT

75.6th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

67.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+38.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

60 days

median, +13.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Raleigh's A+ overall grade is driven by its exceptional labor market, with a 3.0% unemployment rate and 67.67% labor force participation, indicating a deep and engaged workforce. The city's 1.25% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth further underscores its economic vitality, making it a highly competitive market where businesses face significant hiring challenges.

Despite an above-average cost of living, Raleigh's housing market is characterized by a moderate 60-day average time on market, which is slowing down by 13.2% year-over-year. This stabilization is a positive development, given the city's strong employment growth and aggressive expansion of housing supply, as evidenced by a 38.82% year-over-year increase in building permits. The tension between a fast-moving housing market and an affordable cost of living is worth monitoring, as demand may eventually outpace supply and erode the city's affordability advantage.

Raleigh offers businesses a highly skilled and dedicated workforce, a strong and expanding economy, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the primary risk is that the city's housing market, while currently stabilizing, may eventually become a barrier to attracting and retaining talent if demand continues to outpace supply.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

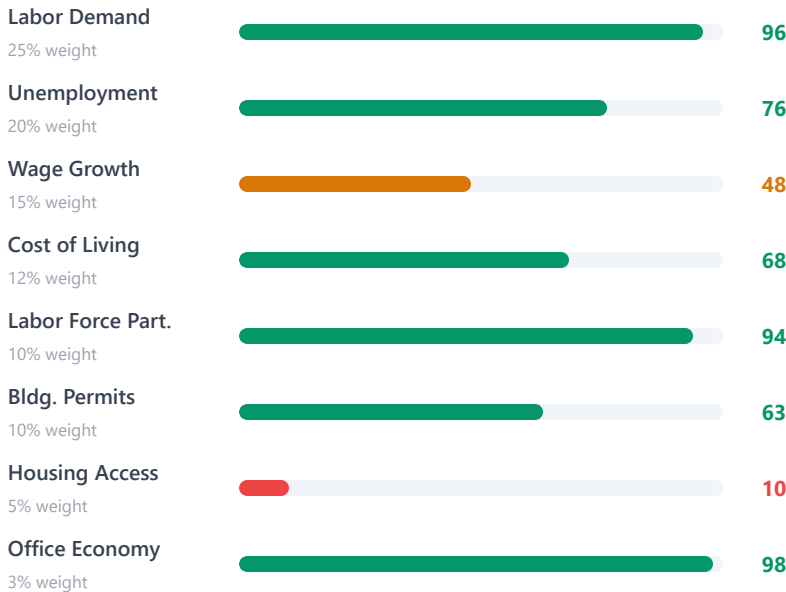
A+

EXCELLENT

73.6th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

72.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+14.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days

median, -15.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City earns an A+ grade, with a single most important takeaway being its exceptional economic character, reflected in a low unemployment rate of 3.40% and a labor force participation rate of 72.77%. The city's labor market is both healthy and deep, with nonfarm employment growth at 1.83% year-over-year, signaling rapid job creation and an economically expanding market. This momentum is underscored by a top-tier office and professional worker share, ranking in the 98th percentile, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses and headquarters.

The city's housing market, however, presents a challenge. With days on market at 49 days and decreasing by 15.5% year-over-year, Salt Lake City is among the fastest-moving markets, driven by above-average employment growth. This fast-paced market, coupled with a cost of living that is below average, may pose a relocation challenge for new hires competing for limited housing stock. Above-average building permit growth offers some relief, but does not entirely mitigate the housing competition.

In summary, Salt Lake City offers businesses a thriving economy with a deep labor pool and rapid job creation, making it an excellent location for growth-oriented companies. However, the primary risk lies in the highly competitive housing market, which may hinder talent attraction and retention due to the challenges new hires face in securing affordable housing in a fast-moving market.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

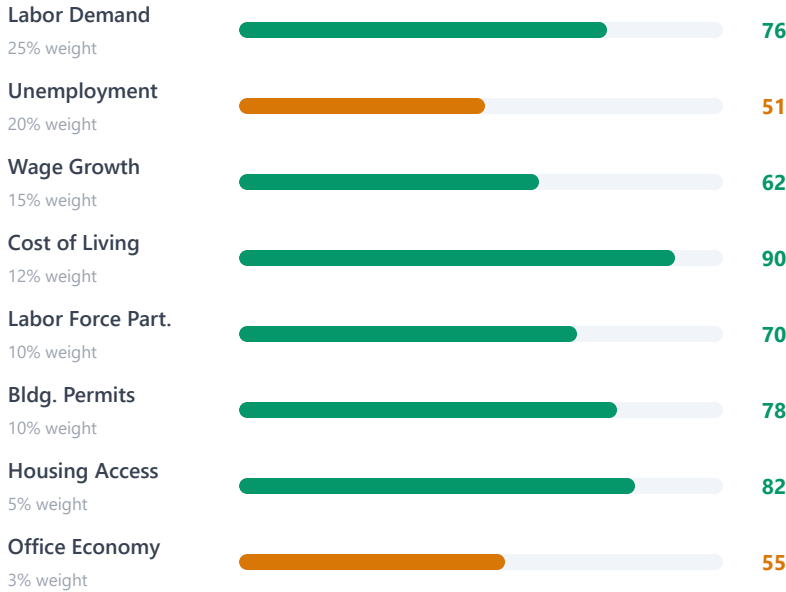
A+

EXCELLENT

69.8th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+20.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

58 days

median, +11.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City earns an A+ grade, driven by its top-tier cost of living and strong economic growth. With a composite index of 1.32, it is one of the most affordable metros in the dataset, making it an attractive location for businesses and workers. The city's above-average nonfarm employment growth of 0.52% year-over-year and solid wage growth of 4.70% year-over-year contribute to its strong economic profile.

The housing market, however, shows a slowing trend, with days on market increasing by 11.5% year-over-year to an average of 58 days. This is a sign of a stabilizing force, given the city's above-average employment growth and strong building permits growth of 20.14% year-over-year. The cost of living advantage also plays a role, making the city an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Oklahoma City offers a unique combination of affordability, healthy employment growth, and a stabilizing housing market, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for the housing market to continue slowing, which could impact demand and affordability if not managed carefully.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

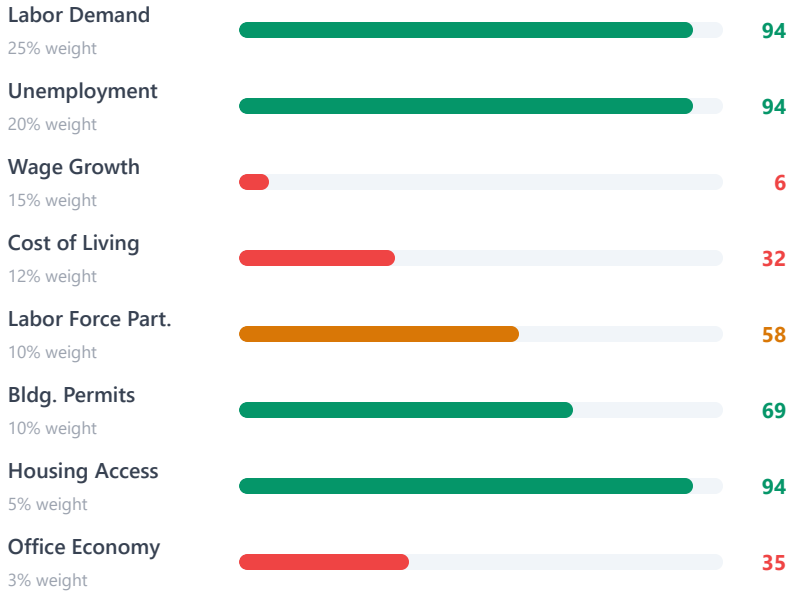
A

VERY GOOD

65.5th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+16.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

46 days

median, +21.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Hartford's economy stands out with an overall grade of A, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market and rapid job creation, with a 2.70% unemployment rate and 1.88% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth. This strong momentum creates a market with significant hiring competition, where businesses face stiff competition for top talent and workers have leverage.

The -0.36% year-over-year wage growth is a warning sign, suggesting that workers may not be benefiting from the tight labor market as much as expected. The cost of living composite, at 3.50, indicates an above-average cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The 21.1% year-over-year increase in days on market, with homes now taking an average of 46 days to sell, could be a sign of stabilization or a warning sign of demand erosion.

Hartford offers a business a highly competitive and expanding market with a strong labor force, but with the caveat that hiring and retaining talent may be challenging due to the tight labor market and stagnant wage growth. The primary risk for businesses is navigating this complex labor landscape while also considering the potential implications of a slowing housing market on the overall economy.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

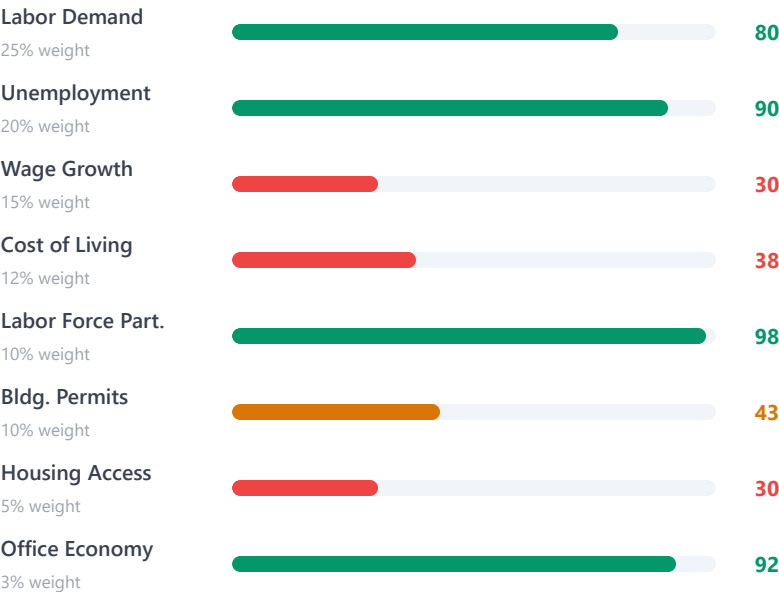
A

VERY GOOD

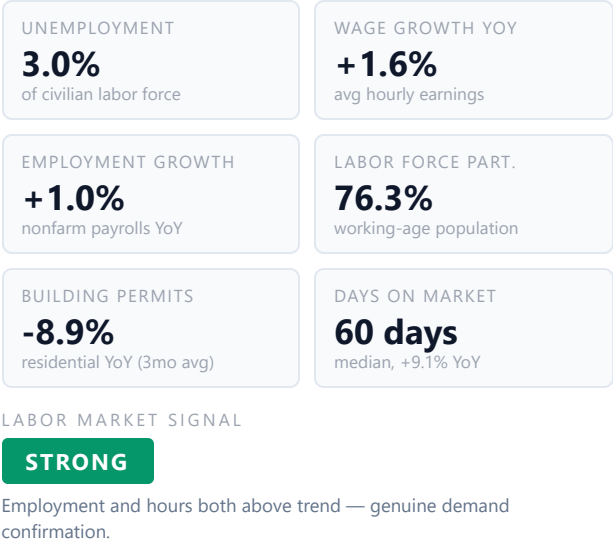
65.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville's economy earns an A grade, driven by its exceptionally tight labor market, with a 3.00% unemployment rate, and a deep labor pool, reflected in a 76.27% labor force participation rate. The city's +1.03% nonfarm employment growth YoY underscores its economically expanding market, making it an attractive location for businesses. A highly engaged workforce positions Nashville as a hub for knowledge-economy businesses and HQ locations.

Despite its strong labor market, wage growth remains sluggish at +1.62% YoY, indicating a lower cost environment for employers but potentially weak worker bargaining power. The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 9.1% more days to sell than last year, averaging 60 days on market. This slowdown, paired with a below-average cost of living score of 3.30, suggests normalization or softening demand.

Nashville offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, deep professional talent pool, and relatively low costs, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to tap into a skilled workforce. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for softening demand, as indicated by the slowing housing market and sluggish wage growth, which could impact the city's long-term economic momentum.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

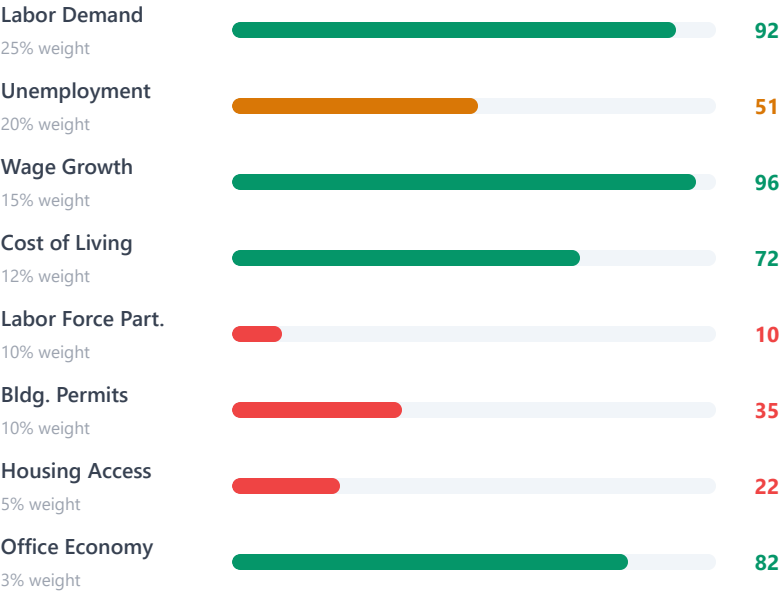
A

VERY GOOD

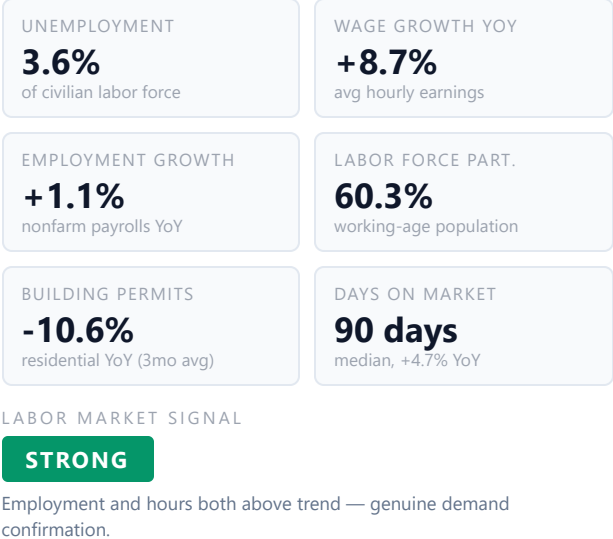
64.3th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh's economy is characterized by strong momentum, with a top-tier nonfarm employment growth rate of +1.07% YoY, indicating rapid job creation, and hourly earnings rising by +8.65% YoY, placing it in the 96th percentile. This expansion is accompanied by a surge in wage growth, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses.

However, labor force participation is critically low, at 60.33%, ranking in the bottom tier, which could constrain workforce availability and limit the city's ability to sustain its current growth trajectory. The housing market is also showing signs of softening, with days on market increasing by +4.7% YoY, and building permits declining by -10.55% YoY, suggesting a potential demand erosion.

Pittsburgh offers a business a dynamic economy with a strong professional talent pool and rapid job growth, but the low labor force participation and potential housing supply squeeze pose significant risks. The city's affordability advantage, driven by a below-average cost of living, may be eroded if demand outpaces housing supply, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Richmond

Richmond

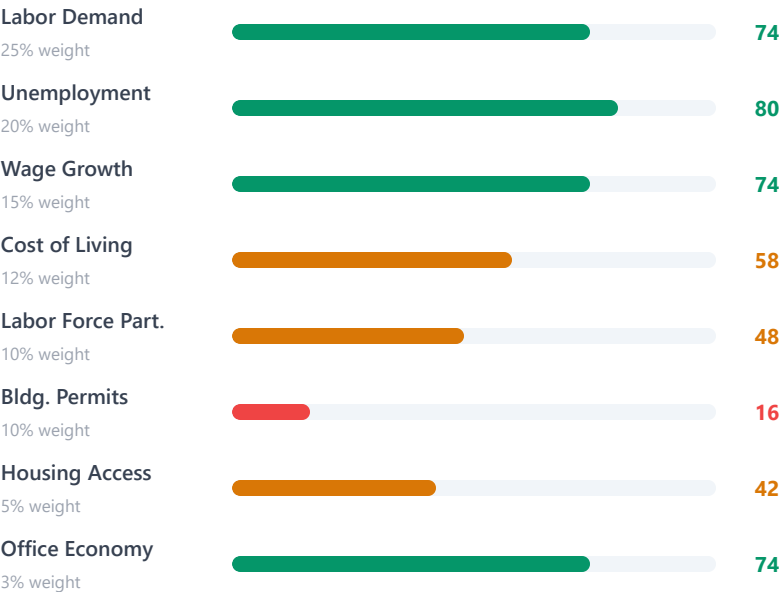
A

VERY GOOD

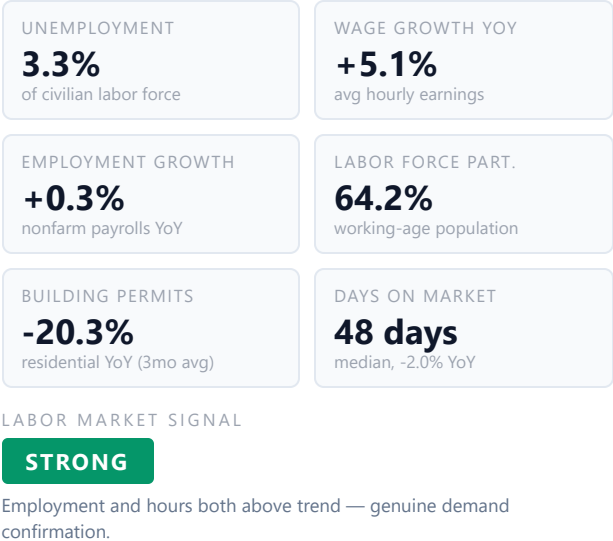
63.2th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Richmond earns an A grade, with a 3.30% unemployment rate and 0.29% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, solidifying its very good economic character. The city's strong labor market is further supported by 5.12% year-over-year wage growth, indicating a constructive environment for consumer spending. Its professional workforce, ranking in the 74th percentile, is a notable strength for office-dependent businesses.

However, a key tension emerges in the housing supply, with building permits declining sharply by 20.27% year-over-year. This is concerning, given that homes are selling faster, with days on market decreasing by 2.0% year-over-year to an average of 48 days. This fast-moving market may be driven more by supply contraction than genuine demand strength, potentially leading to affordability and workforce attraction challenges.

Richmond offers a healthy labor market with strong employment growth and solid wage growth, making it an attractive location for talent and consumer spending. However, the primary risk is the potential housing supply squeeze, which could lead to affordability issues and difficulties in attracting workers, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider the city's housing dynamics when making location decisions.

Birmingham

Birmingham

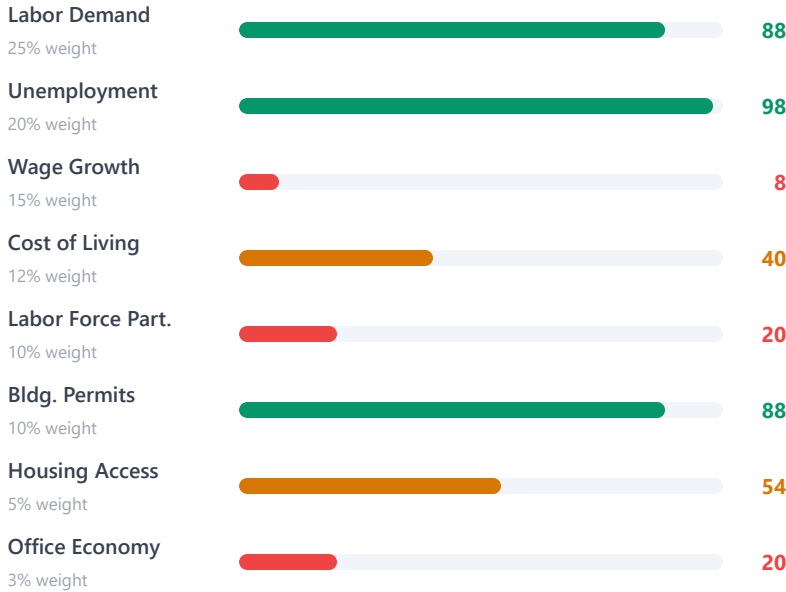
A-

GOOD

61.7th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+55.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

70 days

median, -1.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham's economy is characterized by a remarkably tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.20%, indicating intense competition for workers, and a 0.61% year-over-year increase in nonfarm employment, suggesting an economically expanding market. The labor force participation rate of 60.56% reveals a shallow labor pool, which may constrain business growth despite the low unemployment rate.

The city's labor market tells a nuanced story, with conflicting signals. While the low unemployment rate and strong employment growth suggest a thriving economy, the stagnant wage growth of -0.12% year-over-year raises concerns about consumer spending power. The below-average office and professional worker share, ranking in the 20th percentile, may pose challenges for businesses seeking specialized talent.

Birmingham offers businesses a dynamic and growing economy with a highly competitive labor market, but the primary risk lies in the potential constraints posed by a shallow labor pool and stagnant wage growth. Decision-makers should carefully weigh the benefits of rapid job creation against the challenges of attracting and retaining top talent in this tight labor market.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

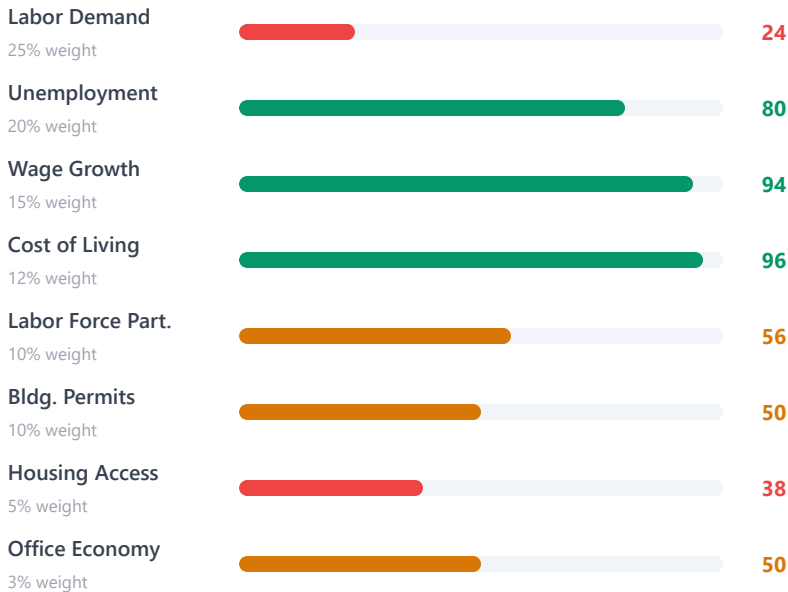
A-

GOOD

61.5th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+8.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

N/A

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

56 days

median, -3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Atlanta's economy earns an A- grade with a 61.5th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros, driven by a low unemployment rate of 3.30% and strong wage growth of 8.27% year-over-year. This suggests a healthy labor market, with workers benefiting from rising earnings. However, below-average nonfarm employment growth of -0.01% year-over-year indicates a potential deceleration in the economy.

The city's strong wage growth is juxtaposed with stagnant employment growth, raising concerns that wages are rising due to a shift towards higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The rapidly changing housing market, with homes selling 3.5% faster than last year, may pose a challenge for relocating workers, who face time pressure and competition in securing housing.

Atlanta's unique combination of low unemployment, strong wage growth, and high affordability, with a cost of living composite score of 1.02, makes it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for economic deceleration, as signaled by below-average employment growth, which may impact the city's long-term economic viability and ability to sustain its current labor market strengths.

Columbus

Columbus

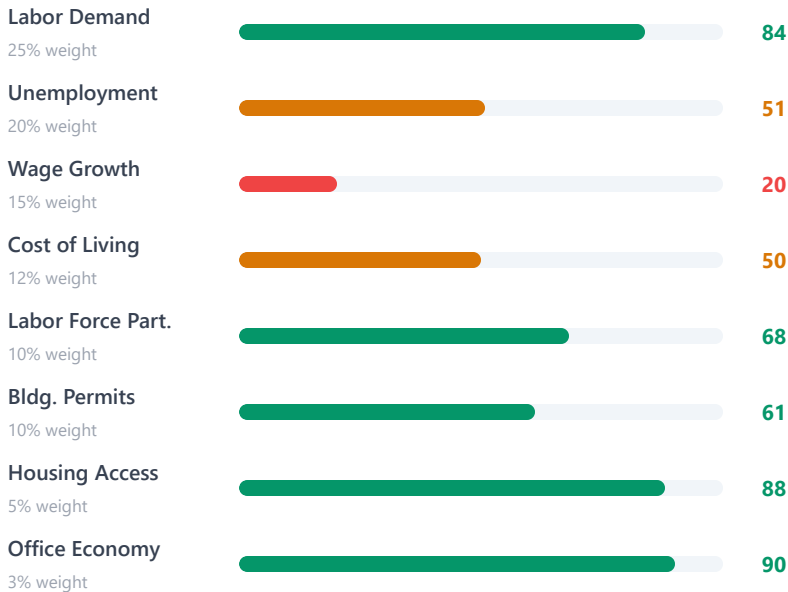
A-

GOOD

60.2th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+8.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days

median, +12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus earns an A- grade, driven by its strong economic momentum, with nonfarm employment growth of +1.17% YoY, ranking in the 84th percentile, and a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 90th percentile for office and professional worker share. This combination suggests a knowledge-economy hub with a strong foundation for businesses requiring specialized skills.

Despite the strong employment growth, wage growth remains sluggish at +0.86% YoY, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a lower cost environment for employers, but also raising concerns about worker bargaining power or softening demand. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 12.2% YoY to an average of 55 days, ranking in the 88th percentile.

Columbus offers businesses a unique combination of strong job growth, a deep professional talent pool, and a stabilizing housing market. However, the primary risk lies in the sluggish wage growth, which may signal underlying weaknesses in the labor market and potentially impact the city's long-term economic momentum.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

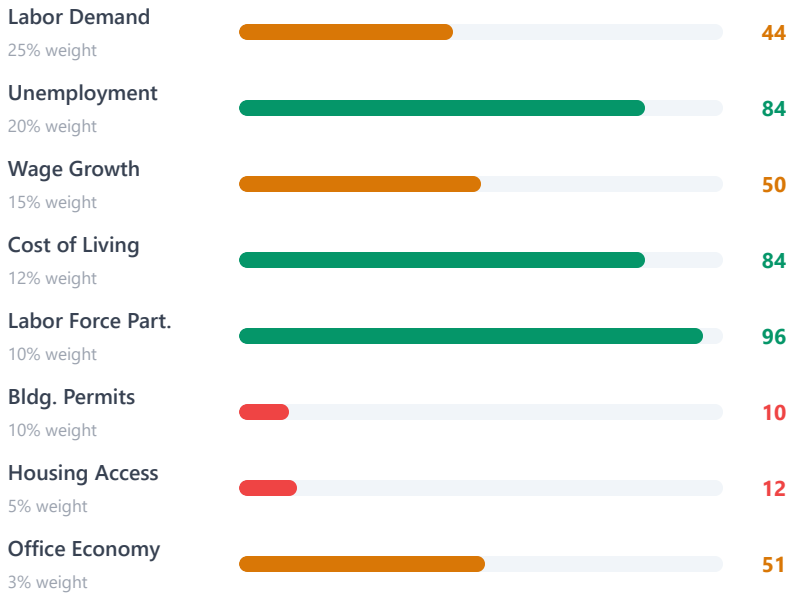
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.1th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

74.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

76 days

median, +15.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Austin's economy earns a B+ grade, ranking 58th among 50 US metros, with a single most important takeaway: its exceptionally tight labor market, with a 3.2% unemployment rate, signals a highly competitive hiring environment where workers have significant leverage. The city's labor force participation rate of 73.99% indicates a strong workforce engagement, and its affordable cost of living, with a composite index score of 1.44, suggests lower real-wage requirements and higher consumer purchasing power.

However, beneath this positive surface, tensions emerge. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing 15.2% year-over-year to an average of 76 days, and building permits declining 29.44% year-over-year, indicating a contracting housing supply. This combination raises concerns about future affordability and workforce attraction, as new hires may face significant housing competition.

In summary, Austin offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, deep labor pool, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition and retention. However, the primary risk lies in the city's housing market, where slowing demand and contracting supply may lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction challenges, potentially undermining the city's economic advantages.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

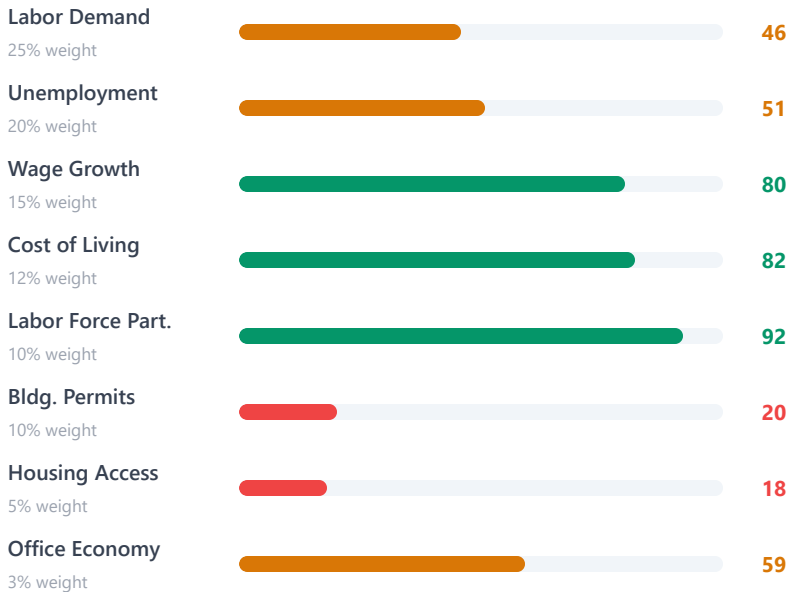
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.5th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

70.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-16.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, -13.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Denver's economy boasts a strong labor market, with a 70.39% labor force participation rate, driving a competitive job market where workers are in high demand, supported by top-tier wage growth of 6.57% year-over-year.

The city's cost of living composite score of 1.48 ranks it among the most affordable metros, offering a significant advantage in terms of lower real-wage requirements and higher consumer purchasing power. However, beneath this positive surface, tensions emerge. The housing market is moving exceptionally fast, with homes selling in just 38 days on average, and this pace is accelerating, with a 13.6% year-over-year decrease in days on market.

Denver offers businesses a unique blend of an engaged workforce, rising wages, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction. However, the rapidly moving housing market, with a 13.6% year-over-year decrease in days on market, and below-average building permit growth of -15.96%, hints at a supply squeeze that could erode Denver's affordability advantage over time, potentially complicating relocation efforts for new hires.

Memphis

Memphis

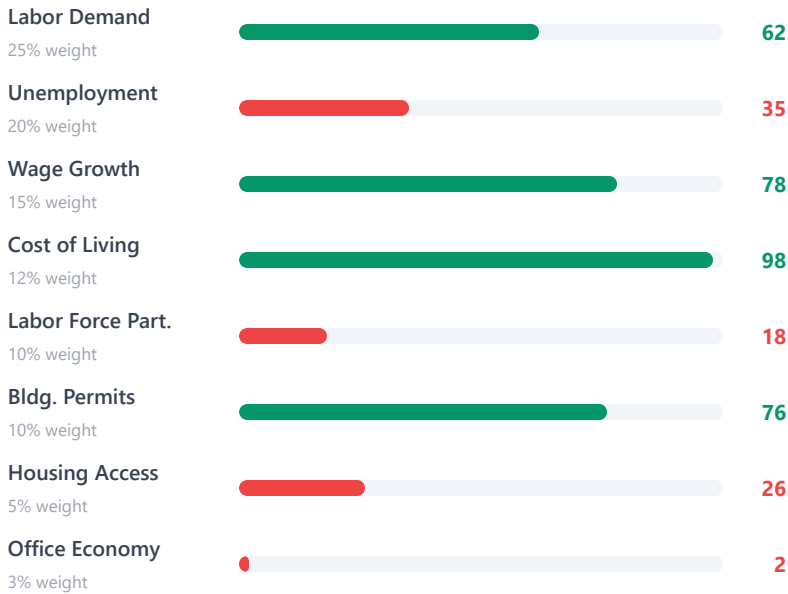
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

56.6th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+19.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

79 days

median, +11.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns a B+ grade, driven by its above-average economic performance, with a low unemployment rate of 4.00% and modest nonfarm employment growth of +0.06% YoY. The city's cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 0.40, ranking it among the most affordable metros, combined with solid wage growth of +6.16% YoY, creates a positive environment for consumer spending and business operations.

However, beneath the surface, tensions emerge. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 11.3% YoY to 79 days, indicating a stabilizing force. The labor force participation rate of 60.48% is critically low, posing a significant structural constraint for businesses considering expansion or relocation. The office and professional worker share is also low, ranking in the 2nd percentile, which may hinder knowledge-economy businesses.

Memphis offers a unique combination of affordability and solid economic growth, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to minimize costs while maintaining access to a growing labor market. However, the low labor force participation rate and limited professional workforce pose significant risks that businesses must carefully consider when evaluating Memphis as a potential location.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

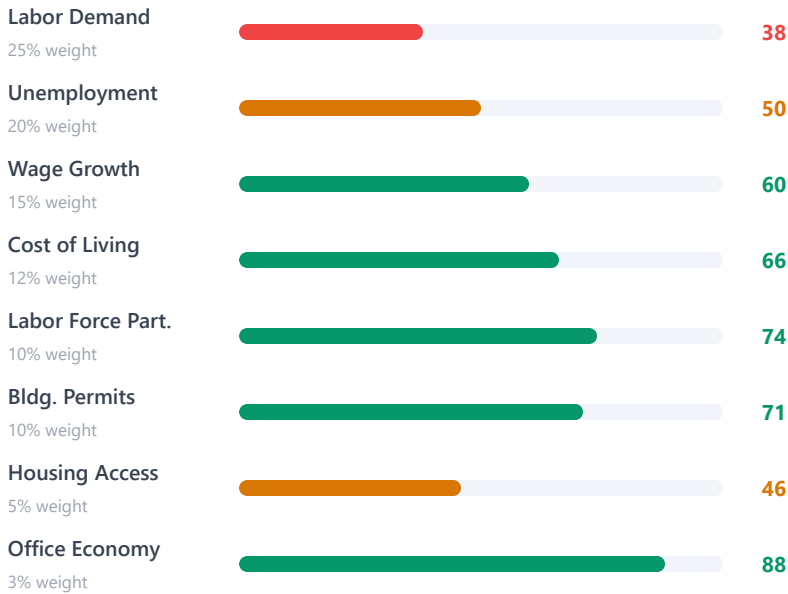
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.9th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

N/A

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

66.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+16.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days

median, -1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler earns a B+ overall grade, driven by solid wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy companies. Hourly earnings increased 4.52% year-over-year, ensuring robust consumer spending, albeit with some cost pressure for businesses. The city's office and professional worker share ranks in the 88th percentile, solidifying its foundation for knowledge-economy businesses and roles requiring specialized skills.

However, beneath this positive surface, signs of economic deceleration emerge. Nonfarm employment growth lags at +0.87% year-over-year, a risk worth watching. The housing market shows mixed signals, with homes selling in 55 days on average, but building permits are growing at an above-average rate of +16.86% year-over-year, indicating that housing supply is keeping pace with demand.

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler offers a talented workforce and a relatively affordable cost of living, with a cost of living composite score of 2.08, making it more affordable than many of its peers. However, the primary risk is the city's below-average job growth, which may indicate a slowing economy and potentially impact the long-term viability of business operations in the area.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

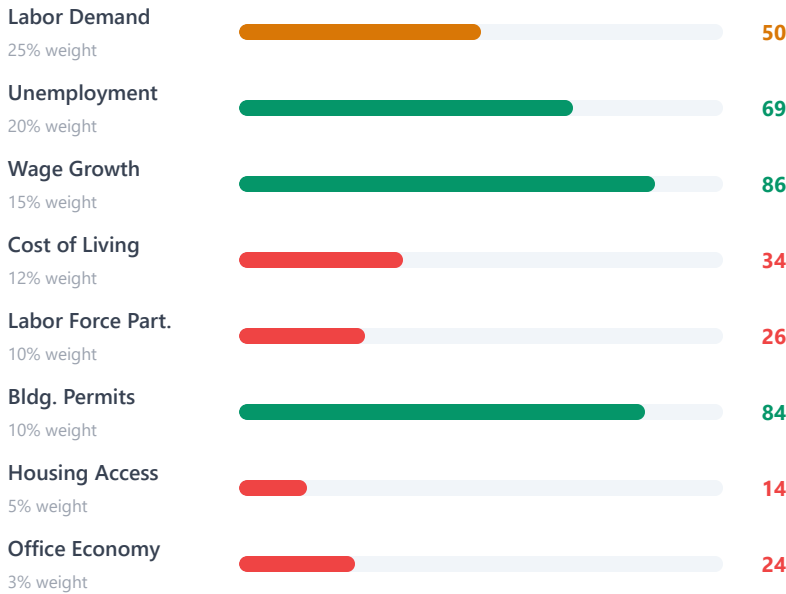
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.8th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+41.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

83 days

median, +12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Miami's economy earns a B+ grade, ranking in the 55.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a single most important takeaway being its dynamic labor market, characterized by a 3.50% unemployment rate and 7.12% year-over-year wage growth. The city's labor force participation rate of 62.53% indicates a relatively shallow labor pool, but strong wage growth is a significant draw, albeit with increased labor costs for employers.

The high cost of living in Miami, with a cost of living composite score of 3.36, limits real purchasing power gains, despite significant nominal wage increases. The housing market is characterized by a slowing pace of sales, with days on market increasing by 12.2% year-over-year to an average of 83 days, despite a 41.11% year-over-year increase in building permits. This complex landscape presents challenges for businesses, particularly in terms of labor costs and housing supply.

Miami offers businesses a unique blend of a dynamic labor market and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies willing to adapt to its high cost of living. However, the primary risk for businesses is the potential for labor costs to outpace productivity gains, making it essential to carefully consider compensation strategies to attract and retain top talent.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

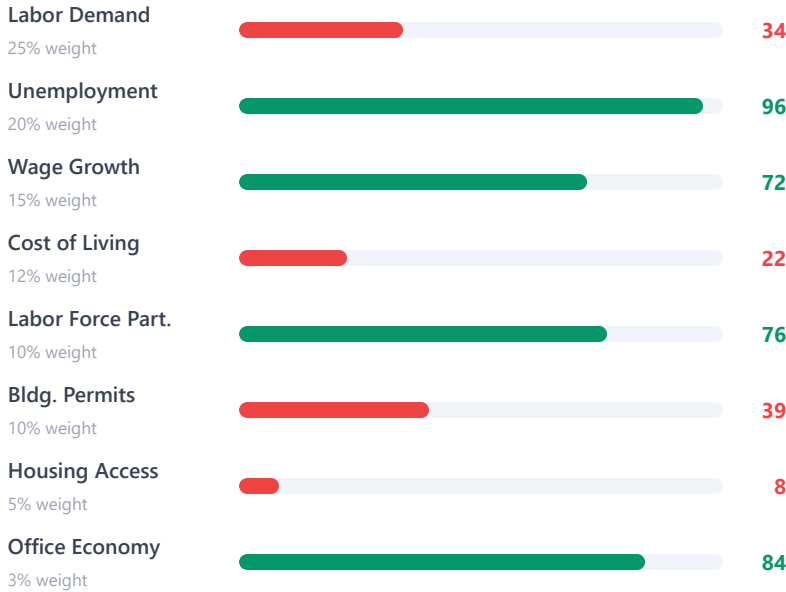
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.5th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

2.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

66.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-10.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

73 days

median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Indianapolis earns a B+ grade, driven by its exceptional labor market, with an unemployment rate of 2.50%, and a deep professional talent pool, ranking 84th percentile for office and professional worker share, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's solid wage growth of 5.10% year-over-year suggests a positive outlook for consumer spending, but with some cost pressure for businesses.

However, beneath this strong surface, there are concerns about economic deceleration and potential housing supply constraints. Nonfarm employment growth lags at 0.11% year-over-year, and building permits have declined 10.26% year-over-year, raising red flags. The cost of living, while not excessively high, is a consideration, with a composite score of 3.94, implying that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Indianapolis offers a talented workforce and a relatively affordable cost of living, but the primary risk lies in its slowing economic growth and potential housing supply constraints. Decision-makers should be cautious about the city's ability to sustain its economic momentum, particularly in the face of declining building permits and softening housing demand.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

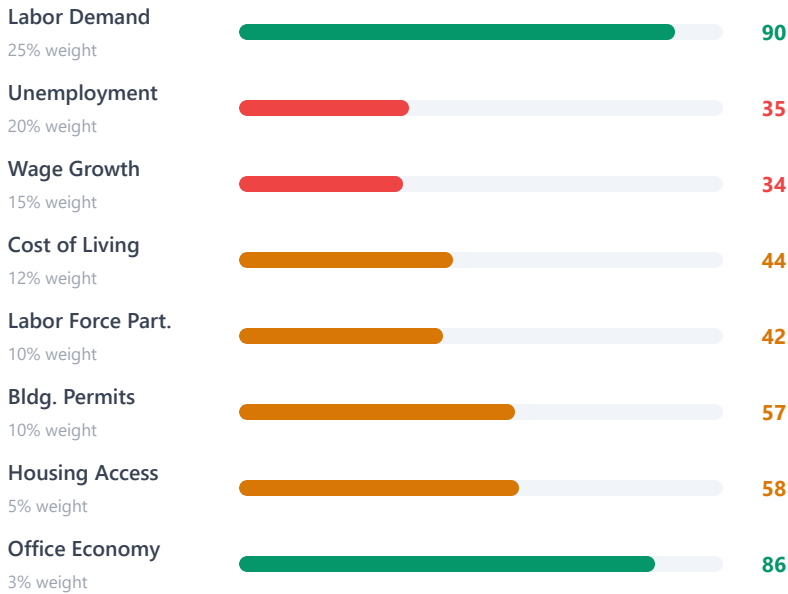
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.2th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+4.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +1.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Philadelphia's economy earns a B+ grade, driven by its strong nonfarm employment growth of +1.16% YoY, ranking among the top tier. This rapid job creation is supported by a deep professional talent pool, with the city ranking in the 86th percentile for office and professional worker concentration. However, the 4.00% unemployment rate and +2.21% YoY wage growth below average suggest labor market slack and weak worker bargaining power.

The city's housing market shows a nuanced picture, with days on market increasing by 1.9% YoY, indicating a slowing market. Despite this, the average of 53 days on market remains relatively fast compared to peers. While a slowing market may be a sign of healthy normalization, the below-average wage growth and elevated unemployment rate introduce tension, highlighting the need for careful consideration of the local labor market's dynamics.

Philadelphia offers a dynamic and expanding economy with a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for labor market imbalances, with elevated unemployment and sluggish wage growth potentially weakening local consumer demand and signaling a need for careful workforce planning.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

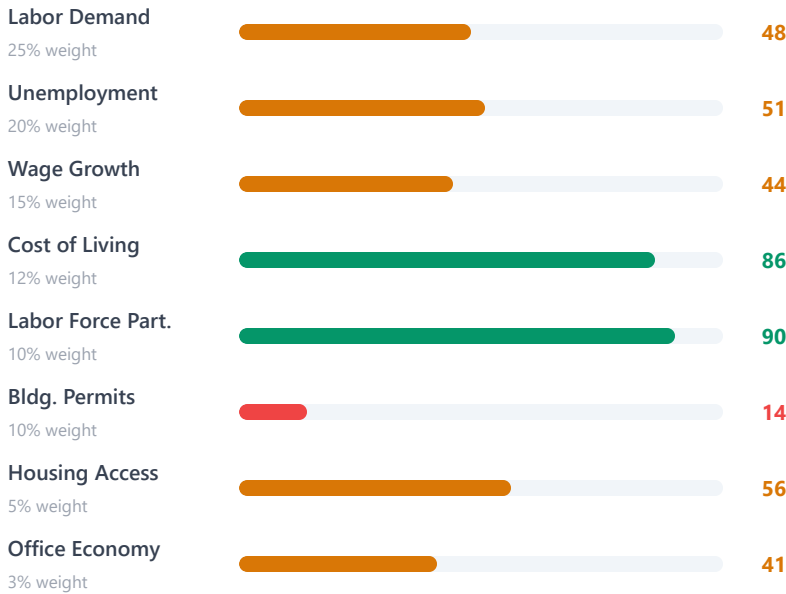
B

AVERAGE

53.6th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

69.6%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-21.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

57 days

median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington's strong labor pool, with a 69.61% labor force participation rate, makes it an attractive location for businesses. The city's cost of living composite score of 1.41 also ranks it among the most affordable metros, offering a significant cost advantage for companies.

However, the city's employment growth of 0.33% year-over-year is steady but unremarkable. A closer examination of the housing supply sector reveals tensions, with a sharp decline in building permits of -20.96% year-over-year, indicating a contracting supply. This, combined with a 1.8% year-over-year increase in days on market, with homes taking an average of 57 days to sell, suggests a slowing market and potential demand erosion.

The city's unique combination of an engaged workforce and affordable cost of living makes it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the primary risk lies in the potential for demand erosion and affordability stress due to the declining housing supply, which may impact the city's long-term economic viability and attractiveness to businesses.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

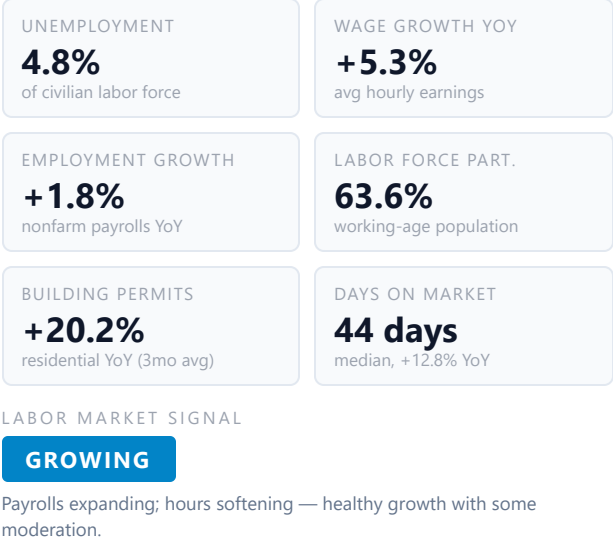
52.5th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim earns a B grade, ranking 52.5th out of 50 US metros, driven by strong nonfarm employment growth of +1.83% YoY and solid wage growth of +5.33% YoY, indicating a momentum-driven market with expanding job opportunities and increasing consumer spending power. However, the high cost of living, with a composite score of 5.59, constrains talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The city's strong employment growth is tempered by a slowing housing market, with a +12.8% YoY rise in days on market, resulting in an average of 44 days. This slowdown can be seen as a stabilizing force, given the city's strong employment growth. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 8th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

In summary, Los Angeles offers a dynamic market with strong job creation and solid wage growth, but at a high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses is the potential for constrained talent acquisition and limited consumer spending power due to the city's expensive nature, which may offset the benefits of its growing economy.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

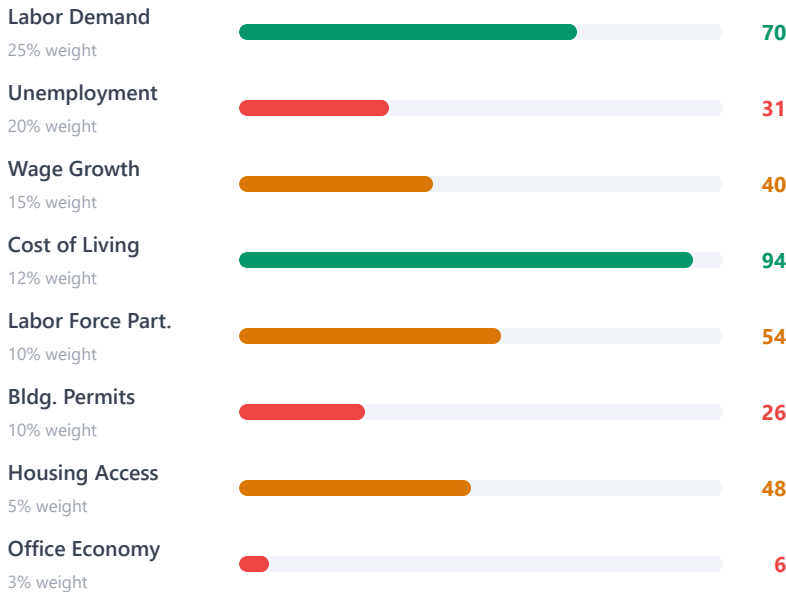
B

AVERAGE

51.5th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

54 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Houston's economy earns a grade of B, ranking 51.5th out of 50 US metros, with a single most important takeaway being its above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.43% YoY, driven by a growing number of jobs across all sectors. However, this growth is accompanied by an elevated unemployment rate of 4.20%, indicating labor market slack and potentially weakened local consumer demand. Houston's cost advantage, with a cost of living composite score of 1.17, ranking it among the most affordable metros in the dataset, provides a significant offset.

Despite these positive trends, the city's office and professional worker share is remarkably low, ranking in the 6th percentile, posing a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The sharp decline in building permits, down 12.89% YoY, raises concerns about a potential housing supply squeeze, which could deteriorate affordability and workforce attraction.

Houston offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and job growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the primary risk is a potential housing supply squeeze, which could undermine the city's affordability advantage and create challenges for workforce attraction, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors in their location decision.

Kansas City

Kansas City

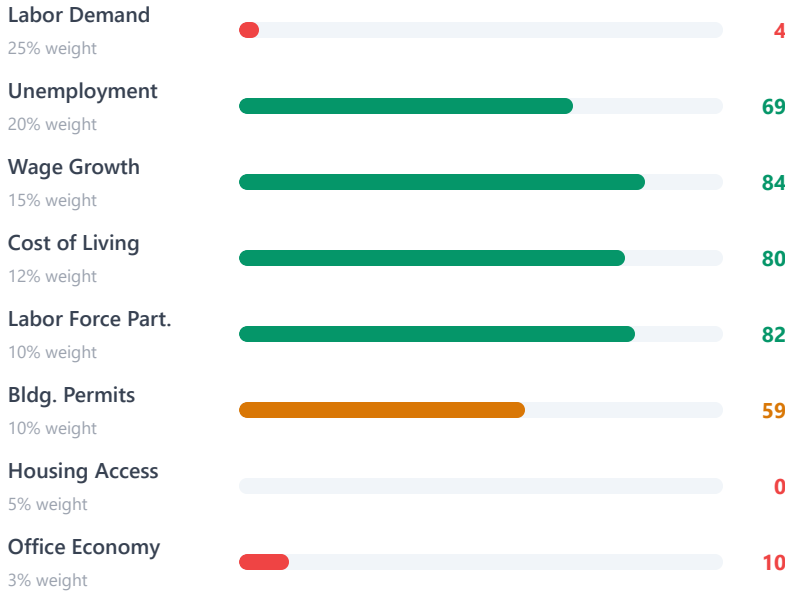
B

AVERAGE

51.5th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

67.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+5.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

57 days

median, -24.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City's economy earns a B grade, ranking 51.5th out of 50 US metros, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and a high labor force participation rate of 67.91%. However, this is offset by a concerning -0.31% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, signaling a contraction in the job market.

The city's strong wage growth of +6.80% year-over-year may be driven by a shift towards higher-paying jobs, rather than broad labor market health. Kansas City's cost of living is among the most affordable, with a composite score of 1.49, but this advantage is eroding due to a fast-moving housing market, where homes are selling 24% faster than last year, with an average of 57 days on market.

Kansas City offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a deep labor pool, but the primary risk is the potential for labor cost pressures and relocation challenges due to the fast-moving housing market. As the city's job market contracts and wages rise, businesses must carefully consider the implications for talent attraction and retention, weighing the benefits of a low-cost environment against the challenges of a competitive housing market.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

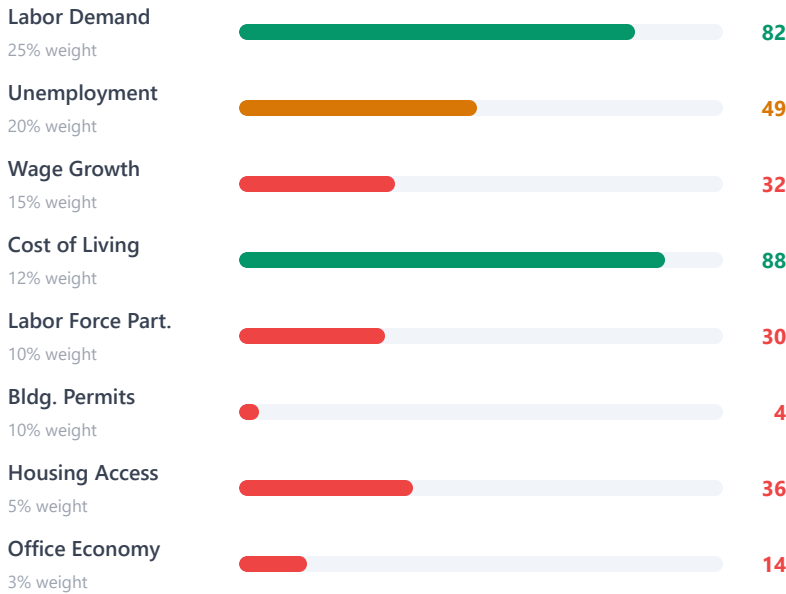
B

AVERAGE

51.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-37.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

79 days

median, +4.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Antonio's economy boasts strong job creation, with nonfarm employment growth of +1.09% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier, and an extremely affordable cost of living, with a cost of living composite score of 1.38, ranking it among the most affordable metros. However, this growth is not without its challenges, as the labor force participation rate is a concern, at 62.78%, indicating a shallow labor pool.

The sharp decline in building permits, down 37.55% year-over-year, suggests a housing supply squeeze is building, which could lead to affordability and workforce attraction issues. The low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking in the 14th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The days on market, at 79 days, is increasing by 4.0% year-over-year, indicating softening demand in the housing market.

San Antonio offers businesses a unique combination of strong job growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and cost management. However, the primary risk is the potential for a housing supply squeeze and affordability issues, which could erode the city's cost advantage and hinder workforce attraction in the long run.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

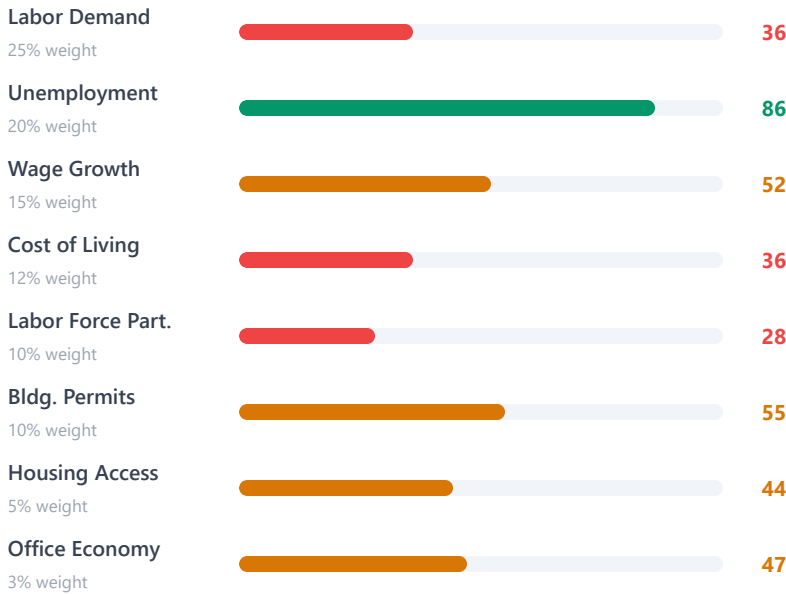
B

AVERAGE

50.2th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.7%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+3.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

50 days

median, -2.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Louisville's economy earns a B grade, reflecting its average standing among 50 US metros, with a tight labor market and low unemployment rate of 3.10% posing significant hiring competition for businesses. However, this is offset by a below-average labor force participation rate of 62.74%, indicating a shallow labor pool.

The city's nonfarm employment growth has been sluggish, with a year-over-year change of -0.06%, signaling economic deceleration. The cost of living composite score of 3.32, below average, suggests that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is also notable, with homes selling in 50 days on market, a relatively fast pace.

In summary, Louisville's business environment offers a tight labor market and relatively low cost of living, but the primary risk is the shallow labor pool and sluggish employment growth, posing hiring challenges and the need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

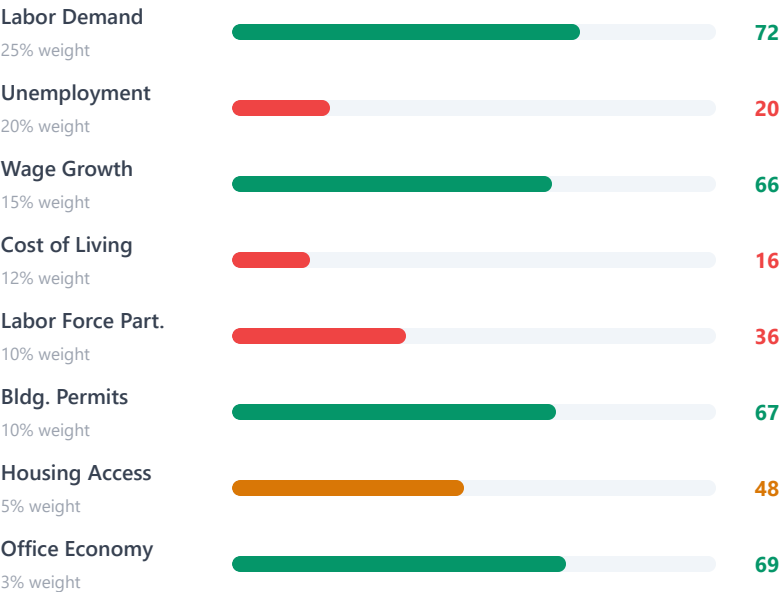
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

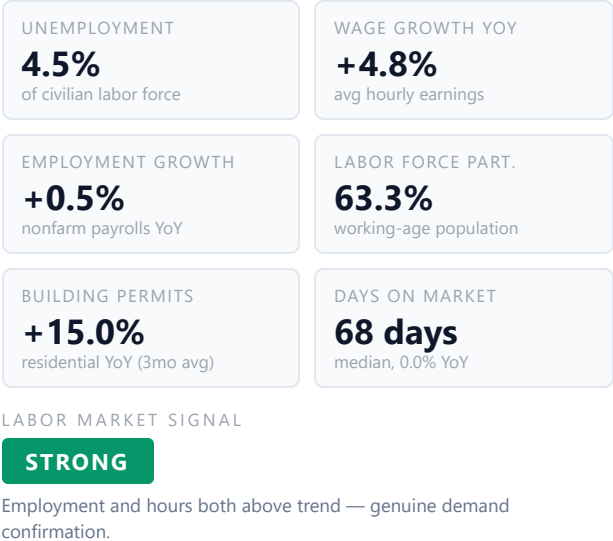
48.7th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

New York's economy earns a below-average overall grade of 48.7th percentile, with a 4.50% unemployment rate and +0.48% nonfarm employment growth, indicating a complex interplay of strengths and weaknesses. Solid wage growth of +4.84% YoY suggests increased consumer spending power, but labor market slack could weaken local consumer demand.

The city's cost of living composite score of 4.78 places it in the bottom tier, making it one of the most expensive metros, and a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. The labor force participation rate of 63.30% is below average, suggesting a shallow labor pool.

New York offers businesses a unique combination of a growing economy and a highly skilled workforce, but the primary risk is the extremely high cost of living, which may deter talent and limit consumer spending. Businesses must carefully weigh the benefits of locating in New York against the potential costs and challenges of attracting and retaining employees in one of the most expensive cities in the country.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

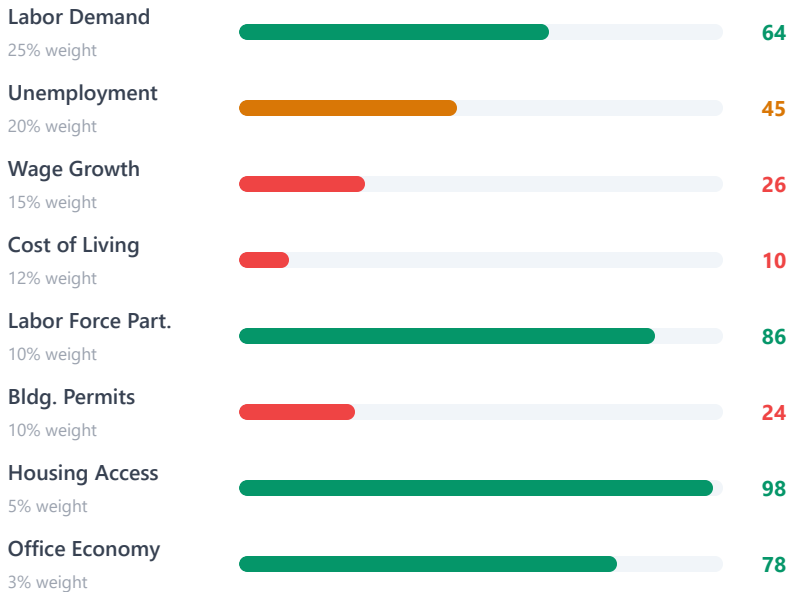
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

68.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

42 days

median, +27.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Boston's economy, graded a B-, is driven by a strong workforce engagement, with a labor force participation rate of 68.47%, and above-average job growth of 0.73% year-over-year, indicating a healthy expansion. However, the city's high cost of living, with a composite score of 5.47, poses a significant constraint on talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market is slowing, with homes taking 42 days to sell on average, and a year-over-year increase of 27.3% in days on market, indicating a potential demand erosion. Sluggish wage growth of 1.42% year-over-year further supports this narrative, implying weak worker bargaining power or softening demand. The above-average professional workforce, with a score of 78th percentile, is a mild positive, but it is overshadowed by the cost of living and housing market concerns.

Boston's economy is defined by its expensive cost of living and slowing housing market, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. While the city offers a deep labor pool and strong professional workforce, the primary risk is the high cost of living and potential demand erosion in the housing market.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

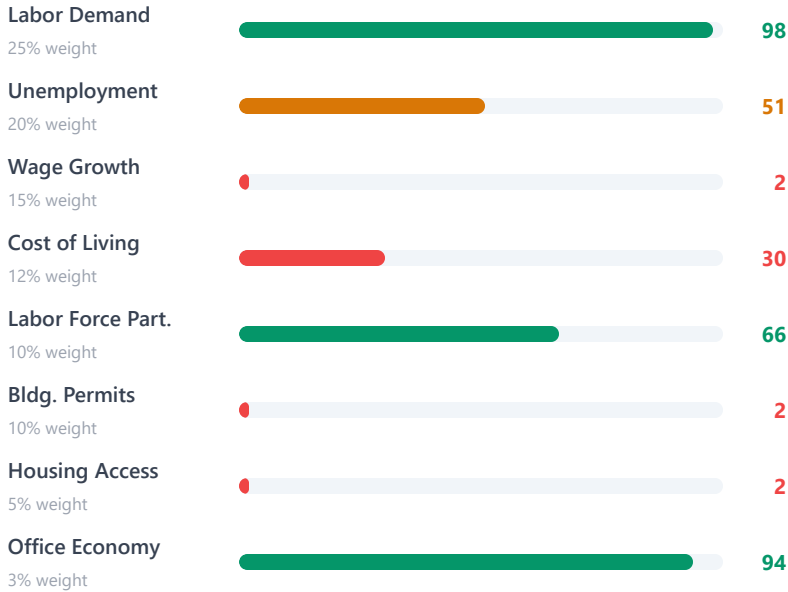
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.3th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+2.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-39.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

69 days

median, +23.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Charlotte's top-tier 2.69% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth defines its economic character, with a 94th percentile ranking for office and professional worker share, indicating a deep professional talent pool. However, this growth is not without its challenges, as stagnant wage growth, with a 1.52% year-over-year decline in hourly earnings, places it in the bottom tier.

The city's housing market is characterized by a sharp 39.50% year-over-year decline in building permits, accompanied by a 23.2% increase in days on market to an average of 69 days. This suggests a slowing market, with the cost of living score of 3.62, while below average, potentially losing its competitive advantage if the housing supply continues to tighten.

Charlotte offers businesses a talented workforce and growing economy, but the primary risk lies in its rapidly tightening housing market. As the city's employment growth outpaces its housing supply, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to rising housing costs and decreased affordability.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

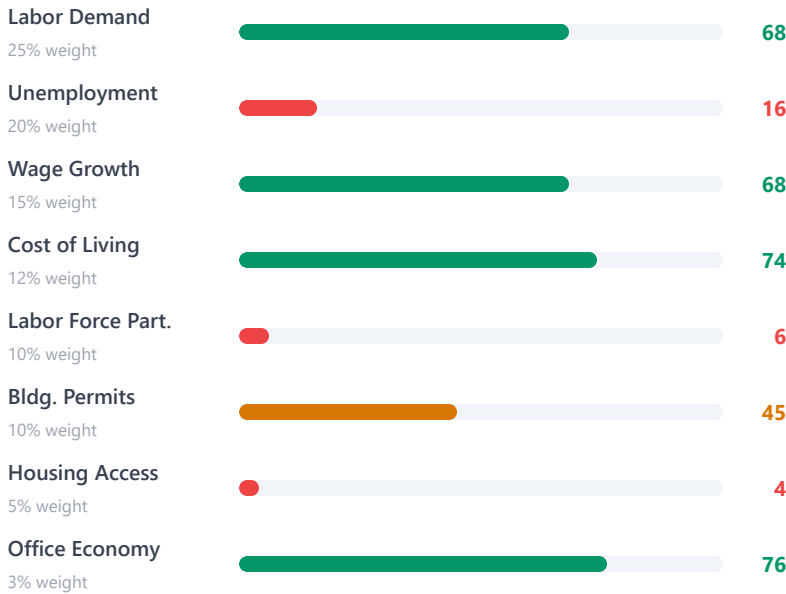
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.9th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.9%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-8.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

80 days

median, +21.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Tampa's economic character is defined by its labor market weaknesses, with a 4.60% unemployment rate and a critically low labor force participation rate of 59.95%, making it a challenging location for businesses. However, the city's above-average nonfarm employment growth of +0.92% YoY and solid wage growth of +4.86% YoY suggest a healthy expansion, which could help mitigate some of the labor market concerns.

Despite these challenges, Tampa's cost of living composite score of 1.87 indicates a below-average cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses and residents alike. The housing market, however, is slowing, with days on market increasing by 21.2% YoY to an average of 80 days, signaling a decline in the market.

In summary, Tampa offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing economy, but the primary risk is the city's labor market weaknesses, which could constrain business expansion and relocation plans. The slowing housing market and low labor force participation rate are key caveats that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Tampa as a potential business location.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

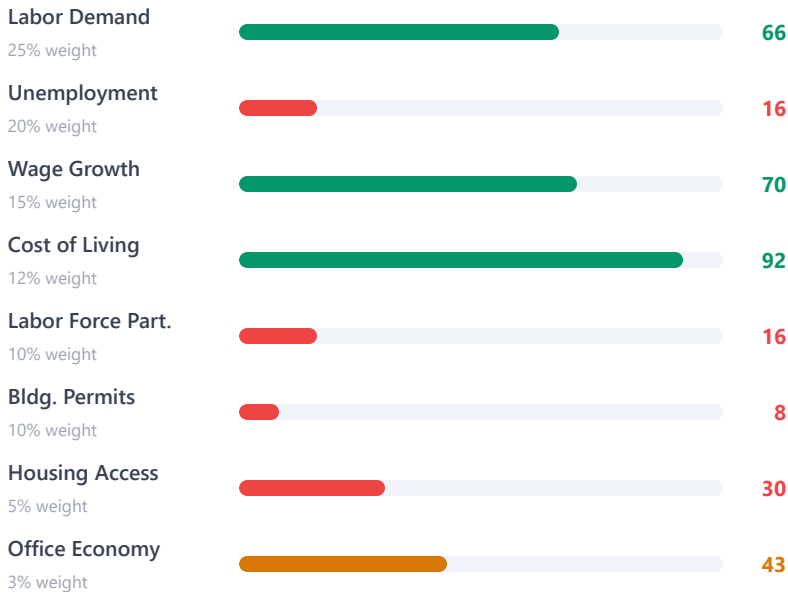
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.5th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-32.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

72 days

median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville's economic character is defined by its labor market weaknesses, with an unemployment rate of 4.60% and labor force participation at 60.38%, making it a challenging location for businesses. However, the city's cost of living composite of 1.31, indicating it is among the most affordable metros, and above-average wage growth of 5.00% YoY, suggest it could offer a competitive edge for talent attraction and retention.

The city's housing market is experiencing a sharp decline in building permits, down 32.70% YoY, and an increase in days on market, up 9.1% YoY to an average of 72 days, indicating a contraction in housing supply and a slowing market. This slowdown may be a sign of demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization of the market, putting upward pressure on prices and eroding the affordability advantage.

In summary, Jacksonville's unique combination of affordability and wage growth makes it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention, but its labor market weaknesses and declining housing supply pose significant risks, particularly if demand erosion continues to slow the housing market and put upward pressure on prices.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

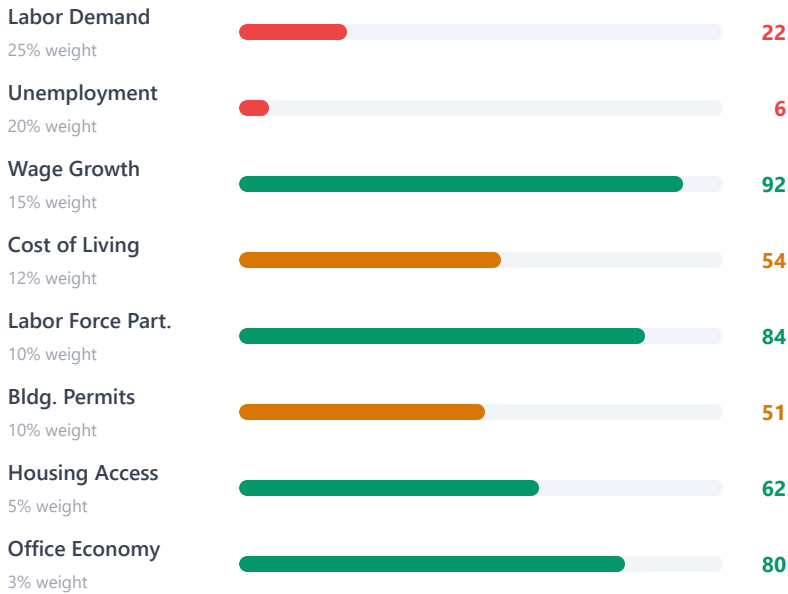
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

68.2%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days

median, +2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Seattle's economy earns a below-average overall grade of 46.0th percentile, driven by a high unemployment rate of 5.00%, indicating severe labor market weakness and a potential risk to consumer spending. A deep labor pool, with a labor force participation rate of 68.24%, and strong wage growth of 7.63% year-over-year, suggest a highly engaged and well-compensated workforce.

However, the city's employment growth is a concern, with nonfarm employment declining by 0.15% year-over-year, a below-average performance. This weakness is mirrored in the housing market, where homes take an average of 36 days to sell, with days on market increasing by 2.9% year-over-year. This slowing market may indicate demand erosion, particularly given the lackluster employment growth.

Seattle offers businesses a highly engaged and well-compensated workforce, but with significant labor market risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering location in Seattle is the potential for demand erosion and labor market instability, which could impact consumer spending and business growth prospects.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

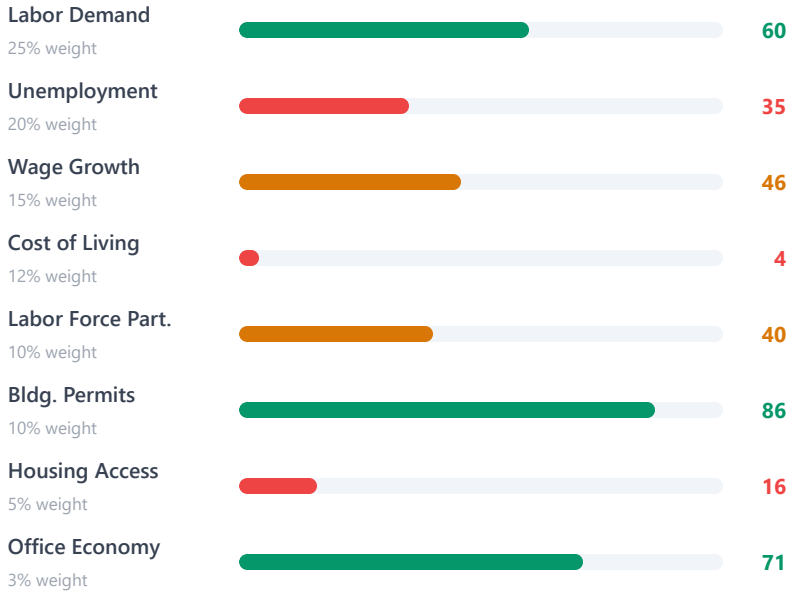
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

63.9%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+55.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

64 days

median, +14.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood's B- grade and 44.8th percentile ranking out of 50 US metros indicate a complex economic landscape. The city's 0.51% nonfarm employment growth outpaces the national average, suggesting a healthy expansion. However, its 4.00% unemployment rate signals labor market slack, making it easier for businesses to hire but potentially weakening local consumer demand.

The housing market presents a nuanced story, with building permits increasing by 55.17% YoY, a top-tier performance indicating aggressive supply growth. However, the days on market have increased by 14.3% YoY, with homes taking an average of 64 days to sell, placing the city in the bottom tier. This suggests a slowing market, but given the strong employment growth and rising permits, this can be seen as a healthy normalization.

Grand Rapids offers a growing economy with an expanding workforce and increasing housing supply, making it an attractive location for businesses. However, the high cost of living and competitive housing market, with homes selling relatively quickly, pose a risk to talent acquisition and affordability, which businesses should carefully consider when making location decisions.

St. Louis

St. Louis

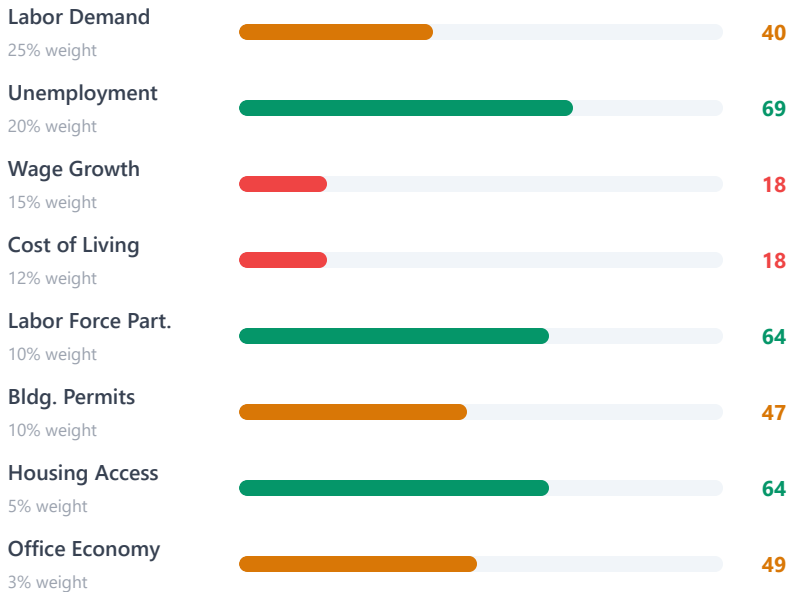
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.5th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.0%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-7.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days

median, +3.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns a B- grade, ranking 44.5th among 50 US metros, with a low unemployment rate of 3.50% and above-average labor force participation of 65.27%, indicating a constructive labor market. However, stagnant wage growth of +0.66% YoY raises concerns about consumer spending power and market health.

The housing market is nuanced, with homes taking an average of 55 days to sell, a moderate pace that is slowing down with a +3.8% YoY increase in days on market. The high cost of living composite score of 4.24, indicating one of the most expensive metros, exacerbates concerns about talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

St. Louis offers a relatively stable labor market, but with significant concerns around affordability and consumer spending power. The primary risk for businesses locating in St. Louis is the potential for softening demand and decreased affordability, which could impact growth and profitability.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

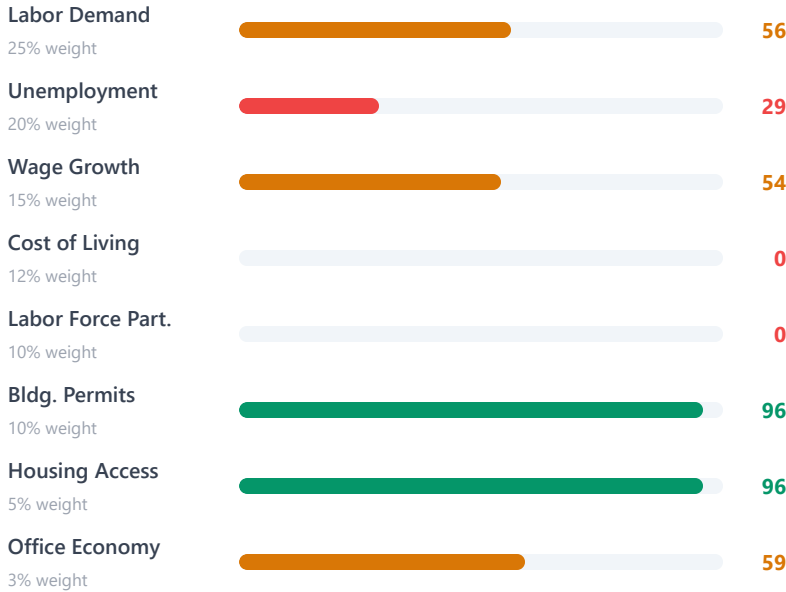
C+

POOR

44.0th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

50.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+144.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

49 days

median, +25.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Providence-Warwick earns a C+ overall grade, reflecting a labor market with significant structural constraints, with a critically low labor force participation rate of 50.77% hindering business expansion or relocation. The cost of living composite score of 7.01 places Providence among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and real consumer spending power. A relatively low unemployment rate of 4.30% suggests some labor market slack that could facilitate hiring.

However, the housing market presents mixed signals. Building permits are surging by 144.37% year-over-year, a top-tier performance that suggests aggressive expansion of the housing supply, potentially alleviating affordability pressures and accommodating a growing workforce. Yet, days on market are increasing by 25.6% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 49 days to sell, indicating a slowdown in the housing market that could be a sign of normalization or softening demand.

Providence offers a complex landscape for businesses, with significant labor market and cost-of-living challenges. The primary risk is that the city's structural constraints, particularly its low labor force participation rate and high cost of living, could outweigh the potential benefits of a growing housing supply and relatively low unemployment rate.

Cleveland

Cleveland

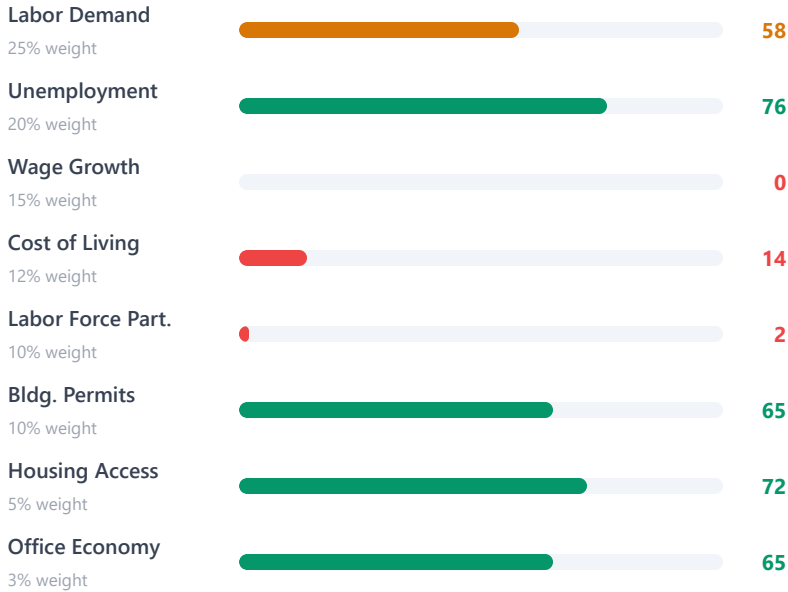
C+

POOR

43.6th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

58.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+15.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

55 days

median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland's economic character is defined by low unemployment, critically low labor force participation, and stagnant wage growth, with a 3.40% unemployment rate and a 58.01% labor force participation rate, indicating a shallow pool of available workers.

The city's cost of living composite score of 5.00, ranking in the 14th percentile, makes it among the most expensive metros, constraining talent acquisition and consumer spending power. However, the office and professional worker share is above average, ranking in the 65th percentile, providing a mild positive for office-dependent businesses. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 7.8% year-over-year to an average of 55 days, providing a moderate advantage for relocating workers.

Cleveland offers a business a low-unemployment environment, but with significant risks related to labor force participation and cost of living, including a shallow labor pool and high cost of living, which could limit the availability of skilled workers and constrain consumer spending, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

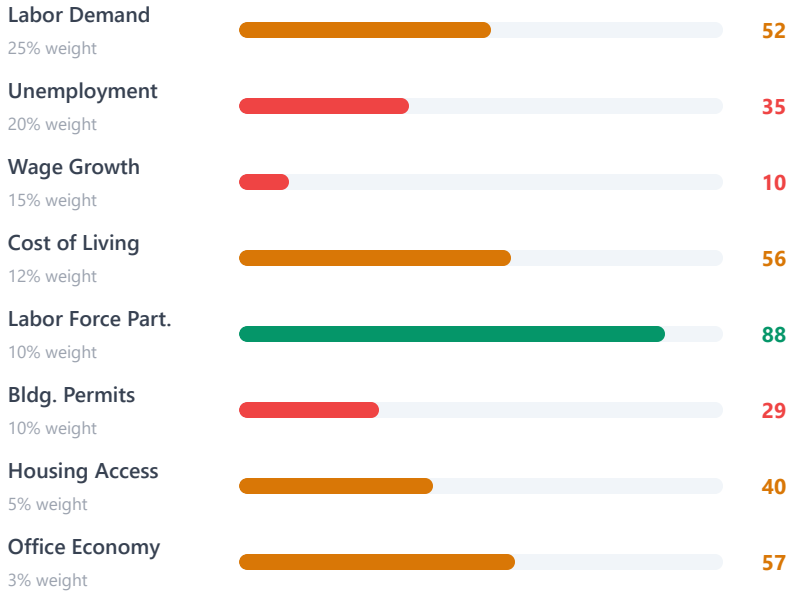
C+

POOR

43.5th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

69.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.2%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, -2.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area earns a C+ grade, ranking 43.5th out of 50 US metros, driven by a combination of labor market factors, including a top-tier labor force participation rate of 69.03% and a below-average unemployment rate of 4.00%. However, wage growth has been stagnant, with hourly earnings increasing by only 0.03% year-over-year, a bottom-tier performance that signals weakened consumer spending power.

The strong labor force engagement is not matched by the housing market, where building permits have declined by 12.25% year-over-year, indicating a potential supply squeeze. Homes are selling in fewer days than last year, with an average of 40 days on market, suggesting a thin-supply illusion rather than genuine demand strength. The stagnant wage growth exacerbates this concern, limiting the ability of workers to afford homes in a tightening market.

Minneapolis offers a strong labor pool with high workforce engagement, but the primary risk lies in stagnant wage growth and potential housing supply constraints. As a business location, Minneapolis provides a strong talent pipeline, but decision-makers must carefully consider the potential affordability and housing challenges that may impact employee attraction and retention.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

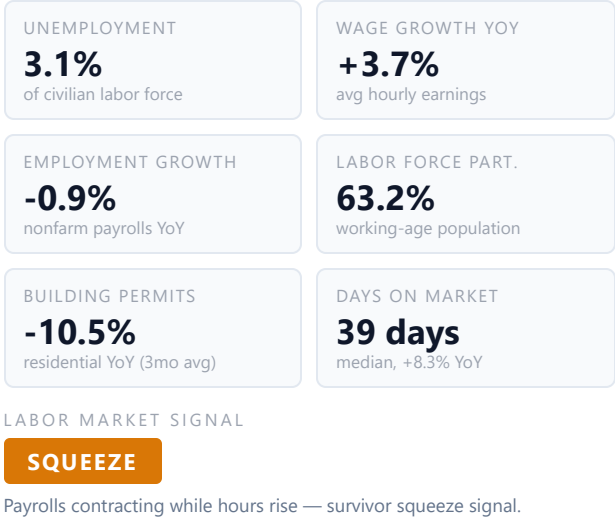
41.6th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Milwaukee's economic character is defined by a tight labor market, with an unemployment rate of 3.10%, and weak job growth, resulting in a -0.91% year-over-year change in nonfarm employment. This dynamic creates a challenging hiring environment for businesses, as available talent is scarce. The labor force participation rate of 63.19% suggests that the labor pool may be shallow.

The city's cost of living and housing market also present notable challenges. With a cost of living composite score of 3.70, Milwaukee has an above-average cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 8.3% year-over-year to an average of 39 days.

In summary, Milwaukee offers businesses a highly competitive labor market, but with significant hiring challenges due to a shallow labor pool. The primary risk for businesses locating in Milwaukee is the potential for demand erosion, driven by weak job growth and a slowing housing market, which may impact the city's long-term economic viability.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

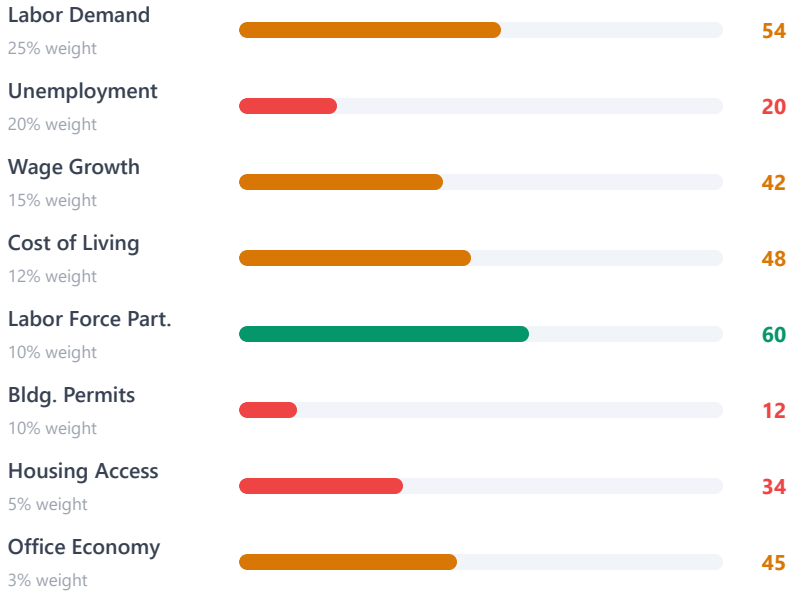
C+

POOR

39.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.8%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-27.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, -7.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Chicago's economic character is defined by its labor market slack and housing supply constraints, with a single most important takeaway being the city's housing supply constraints posing a significant risk to businesses. With an unemployment rate of 4.50%, the city's labor market is experiencing slack, which could make hiring easier but also potentially weaken local consumer demand. The labor force participation rate of 64.75% is a mild positive, indicating a relatively available workforce.

The sharp decline in building permits, down 27.41% year-over-year, suggests a contracting housing supply, which could lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. Homes are selling faster than in most metros, with an average of 40 days on market, and this pace is accelerating, with a 7.0% year-over-year decline in days on market. This could be a sign of a competitive market for buyers, but given the weak building permits, it may also be a thin-supply illusion rather than genuine demand strength.

Chicago offers a business a labor market with some slack and a relatively available workforce, but the primary risk is the city's housing supply constraints, which could lead to affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulties. The sharp decline in building permits and the accelerating pace of home sales suggest a potentially challenging environment for relocating workers to find affordable housing, which could be a significant caveat for businesses considering locating in the city.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

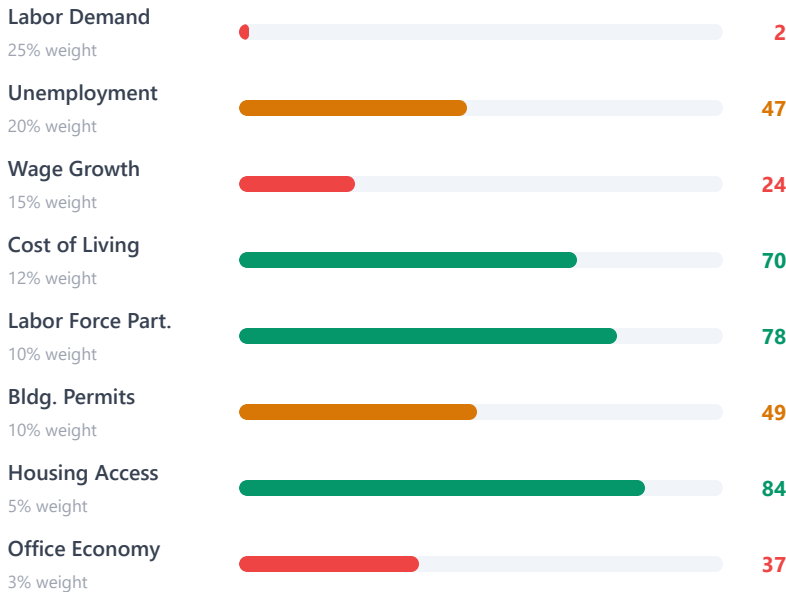
C+

POOR

39.9th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

67.4%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-4.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, +11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Washington D.C.'s labor market is in a state of contraction, with nonfarm employment growth plummeting 1.63% year-over-year, the worst performance in the country. This decline is accompanied by sluggish wage growth of 1.37% year-over-year, indicating a weak labor market with limited bargaining power for workers. The city's high labor force participation rate of 67.37% suggests a readily available workforce, but this is overshadowed by the struggling labor market.

The housing market is also experiencing a slowdown, with days on market increasing by 11.8% year-over-year to an average of 38 days, indicating a decline in demand. This erosion in demand, combined with the weak labor market, suggests that the city's cost of living, which is above average at 1.90, does not offset the labor market weaknesses. The office and professional worker share is below average, ranking in the 37th percentile, which may further constrain access to specialized talent.

Washington D.C. offers a readily available workforce, but its struggling labor market and slowing housing market pose significant risks. The primary caveat for businesses considering location in this city is the potential for demand erosion and limited access to specialized talent, which may outweigh any advantages of a readily available workforce.

Fresno

Fresno

C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

8.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.3%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+62.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +10.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno's economy is characterized by severe labor market weakness, with an 8.20% unemployment rate and a 60.33% labor force participation rate, resulting in near-stagnant job growth of 0.22% year-over-year.

The city's housing market is expanding, with building permits increasing by 61.97% year-over-year, but this growth is not translating to a faster pace of sales, with homes taking 10.4% longer to sell, averaging 53 days. The low concentration of professional and office workers, ranking in the 4th percentile, further constrains the city's appeal for knowledge-economy businesses.

Fresno's labor market weaknesses and slowing housing market pose significant risks for businesses considering relocation, outweighing the city's relatively affordable cost of living and expanding housing supply. The city's structural labor market challenges make it a less attractive location for businesses dependent on a strong and skilled workforce.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

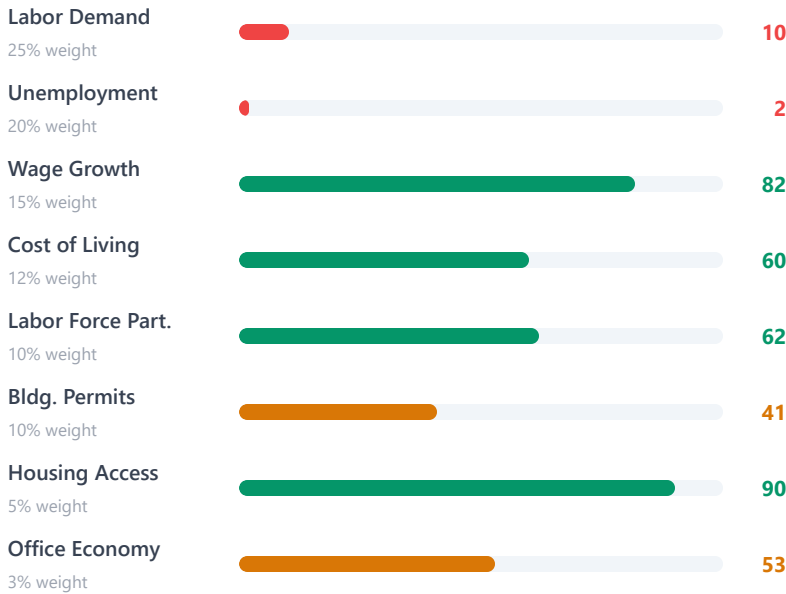
C+

POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

65.0%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-9.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days
median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area earns a C+ grade, ranking 38.8th out of 50 US metros, driven by a stagnant labor market with an unemployment rate of 5.20% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.76% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the job market. Despite this, wage growth remains robust at +6.71% year-over-year, suggesting that while jobs may be scarce, those that exist are becoming more lucrative.

The wage growth, however, may be driven by a shift towards higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 12.8% year-over-year to an average of 53 days, indicating a relatively slow and buyer-friendly market. This slowdown is notable given the weak employment growth, suggesting that demand may be eroding rather than simply normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Las Vegas presents a complex and potentially high-risk environment for businesses, with a slowing labor market and rising wages posing challenges for employers. The primary risk for businesses considering location in Las Vegas is the risk of demand erosion, driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which could undermine the viability of new investments.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

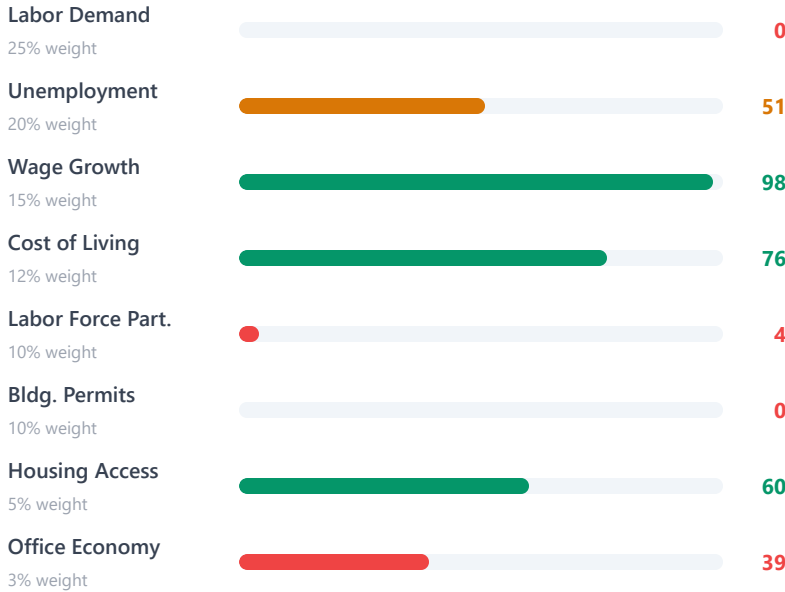
C+

POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+10.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

59.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-46.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area earns a C+ grade, ranking 38.6th out of 50 US metros, with a concerning economic landscape characterized by critically low labor market participation, at 58.99% of working-age adults employed or actively seeking work. The area's nonfarm employment growth has declined by 1.34% year-over-year, and building permits have plummeted by 46.79%, indicating a contracting housing supply.

Despite these challenges, the metro area boasts top-tier wage growth, with hourly earnings rising 10.22% year-over-year. However, this strong wage growth may be masking underlying labor market weaknesses, such as a shift toward higher-paying jobs rather than broad labor market health. The days on market for homes have increased by 2.6% year-over-year, to an average of 40 days, suggesting a slowing housing market that may be indicative of demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization.

In summary, Virginia Beach offers a cost advantage, with above-average affordability, but this comes with significant labor market and housing supply risks. Businesses considering relocation or expansion in this area should be aware of the potential for workforce constraints and affordability stress, driven by the contraction in employment and housing supply, which may outweigh any cost advantages and pose a significant challenge to long-term growth and success.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

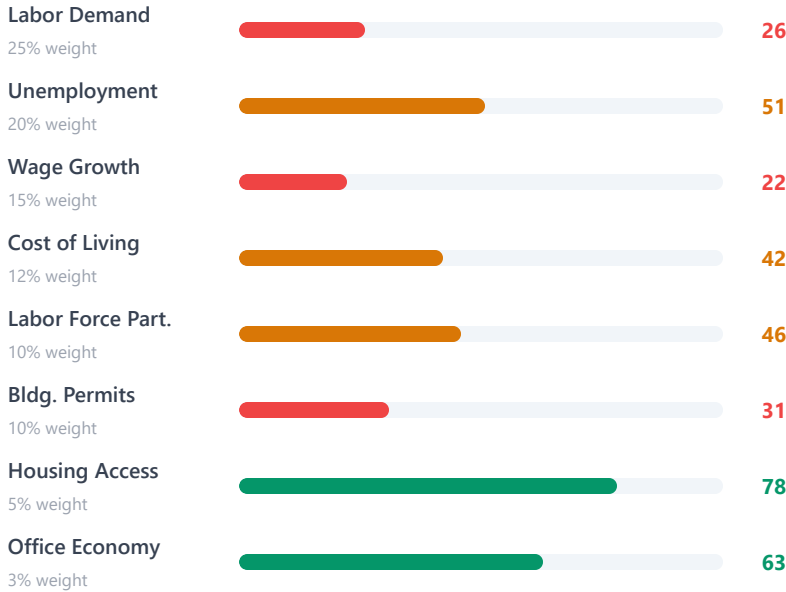
C+

POOR

38.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.2%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Baltimore's economy earns a C+ grade, driven by sluggish wage increases and below-average job growth, with nonfarm employment growth declining 0.14% year-over-year and wage growth at a modest 1.22% year-over-year. This slow pace of economic expansion is further exacerbated by a decline in building permits, down 11.14% year-over-year, indicating a potential tightening of the housing supply.

The housing market is characterized by a moderate buyer's market, with days on market increasing 9.8% year-over-year to an average of 45 days. However, this slowdown may be a sign of demand erosion, rather than a healthy normalization, given the weak employment growth and declining building permits. The presence of an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 63rd percentile, is a mild positive, but it may not be enough to offset the broader economic concerns.

Baltimore offers a business a relatively stable, albeit slow-growing, economy with a moderate cost of living, but the primary risk is the potential for demand erosion and a tightening housing supply. Decision-makers should be cautious of the city's below-average job growth and declining building permits, which may signal a weakening economic environment.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

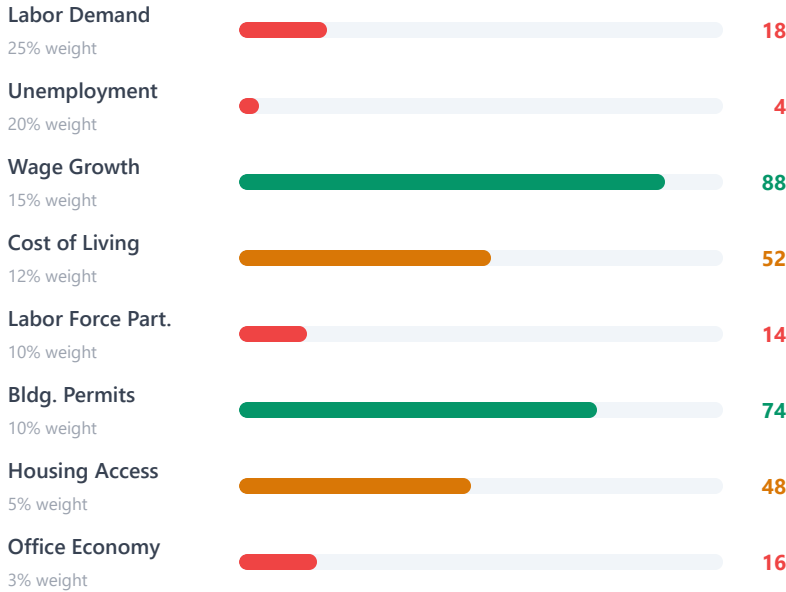


VERY POOR

36.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+7.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.4%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+18.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

60 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area earns a C grade, ranking 36.4th out of 50 US metros, driven by severe labor market weakness. Unemployment rates stand at 5.10%, and labor force participation is critically low at 60.37%. This landscape poses significant risks to consumer spending and business growth.

Wage growth, however, tells a different story, with hourly earnings rising by +7.54% YoY, placing it in the top tier. This disconnect between strong wage growth and stagnant employment raises questions about the underlying drivers of wage increases, potentially due to a mix shift towards higher-paying industries. The low concentration of office and professional workers, ranking 16th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses.

The city's above-average building permit growth of +18.04% YoY offers a mild positive note, suggesting some efforts to address housing supply. However, this is not enough to offset the labor market concerns. Riverside presents a high-risk, potentially high-reward environment for businesses, with strong wage growth but significant labor market challenges. Decision-makers must carefully weigh these factors before making a location decision.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati



VERY POOR

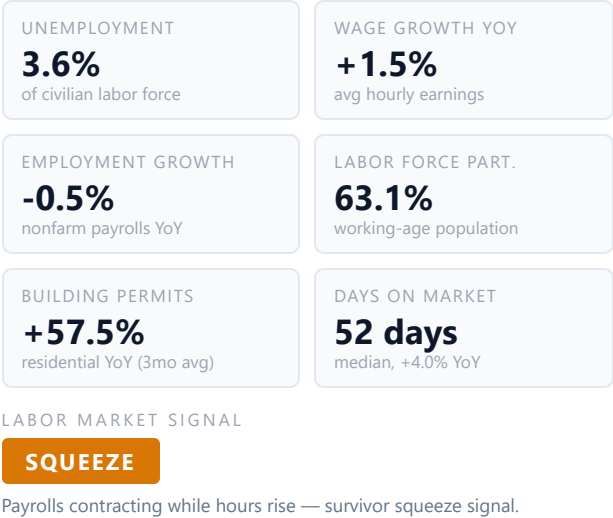
36.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati's economic landscape is defined by its struggling labor market, with a bottom-tier nonfarm employment growth of -0.52% year-over-year, indicating job losses and stagnation, and a labor force participation rate of 63.08%, below the national average.

The city's wage growth is also sluggish, at +1.53% year-over-year, suggesting weak worker bargaining power and softening demand. This is further exacerbated by a cost of living index of 3.69, above average, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. The city's aggressive housing supply expansion, with building permits up 57.47% year-over-year, may not be enough to offset the economic softness.

Overall, Cincinnati's business environment offers a relatively low-cost workforce, but the primary risk is the city's stagnant labor market and potential demand erosion. Businesses must carefully consider the local economic conditions, including the slowing housing market, with homes taking 4.0% more days to sell than last year, averaging 52 days, before making a location decision.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro



VERY POOR

35.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.8%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

66.2%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

68 days
median, -9.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Portland's economic character is defined by its severe labor market weakness, with an unemployment rate of 4.90% and nonfarm employment growth of -0.69% year-over-year, indicating a contraction story. This is further exacerbated by a low office and professional worker concentration, ranking in the 12th percentile, which poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The city's cost of living is below average, with a composite score of 2.18, offering a mild cost advantage.

However, the housing market is a concern, with a sharp decline in building permits of -18.14% year-over-year, which could lead to future affordability stress and workforce attraction difficulty. The city's solid wage growth of +4.78% year-over-year may not be enough to offset the labor market weaknesses and potential housing affordability issues.

In summary, Portland offers a business a cost advantage due to its below-average cost of living, but the primary risk is the city's struggling labor market and potential housing affordability issues. The severe labor market weakness and supply contraction in the housing market pose significant challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, making it a cautious location decision.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

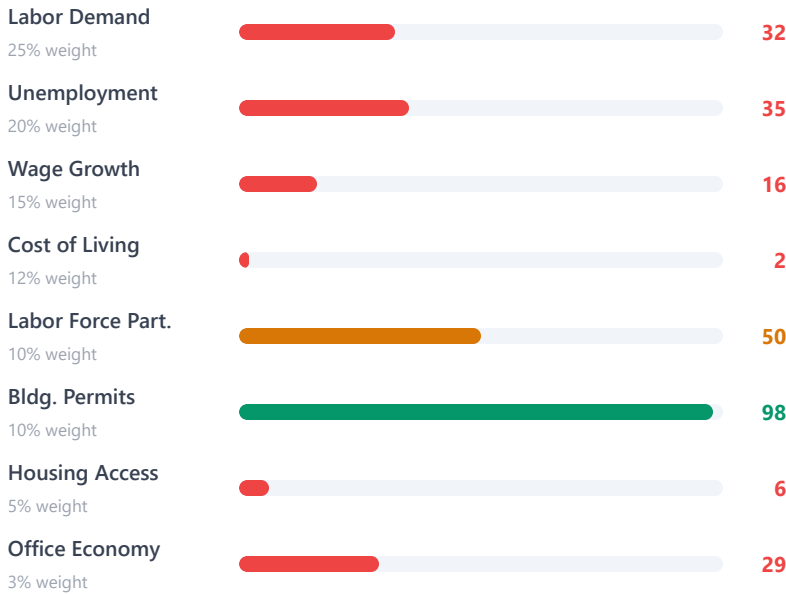


VERY POOR

33.5th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.3%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+195.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

23 days
median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Jose's sluggish labor market and extremely high cost of living define its economic character, with a 4.00% unemployment rate and -0.16% year-over-year nonfarm employment growth, indicating deceleration. Wage growth is stagnant at +0.59% year-over-year, limiting workers' leverage and potentially weakening consumer spending.

The city's cost of living composite score of 6.96, among the lowest 2% of metros, underscores the significant affordability challenges faced by residents and businesses. Despite this, San Jose is experiencing a surge in housing supply, with building permits increasing by 195.09% year-over-year. However, the days on market metric suggests a slowing market, with homes taking 23 days to sell on average, increasing by 4.5% year-over-year.

San Jose offers a highly educated and skilled workforce, but at a significant cost due to its extremely high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses considering locating in San Jose is the potential for weakened consumer demand and limited access to affordable talent, which could hinder long-term growth and profitability.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

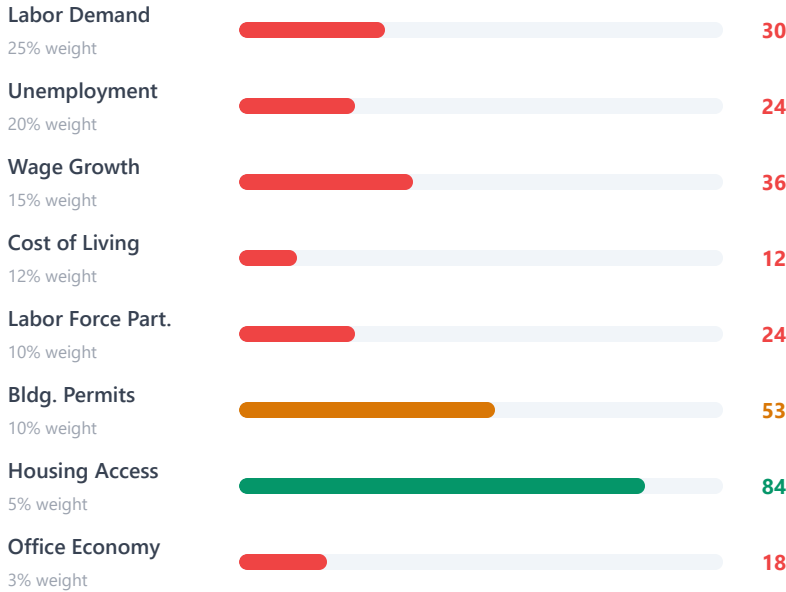


CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

62.0%
working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-0.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days
median, +11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Diego's sluggish labor market and high cost of living define its economic character, with a 4.40% unemployment rate and 62.01% labor force participation, indicating a shallow and stagnant labor pool. The city's nonfarm employment growth is a mere 0.35% year-over-year, reflecting economic deceleration.

The housing market is slowing, with days on market increasing by 11.8% year-over-year to an average of 38 days, suggesting demand erosion. The low office and professional worker share, ranking in the 18th percentile, constrains knowledge-economy businesses. This combination of factors creates tension, as the slowing housing market and high cost of living may deter talent acquisition and limit real consumer spending power.

San Diego offers a high-cost, slow-growth environment with a shallow labor pool, posing a significant risk of demand erosion driven by weak employment growth and a slowing housing market, which may limit the city's appeal to businesses reliant on a strong, skilled workforce.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

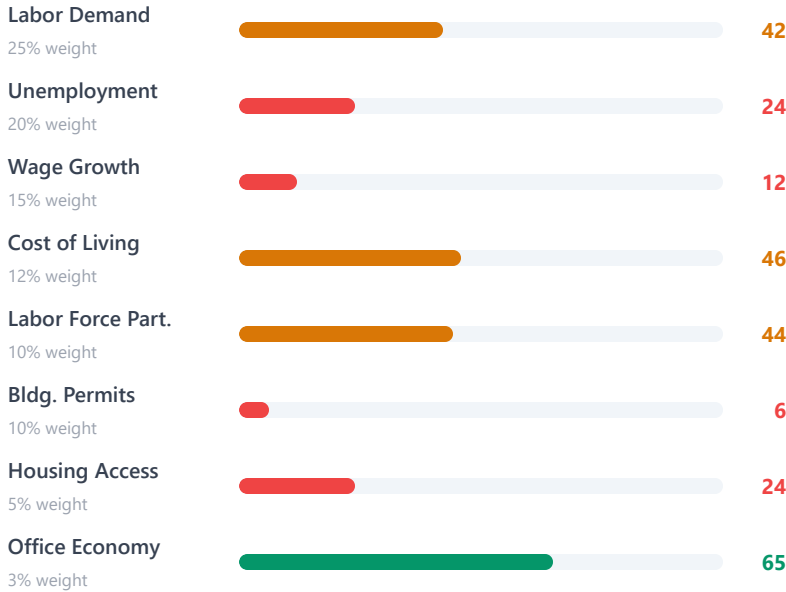
C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.0%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-35.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

82 days

median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Orlando's economic landscape earns a C- grade, marked by a labor market with significant slack and a housing supply under pressure. The 4.40% unemployment rate indicates flexibility for hiring, but also potential weakness in local consumer demand. Stagnant wage growth at +0.37% YoY suggests workers have limited leverage, which could soften consumer spending.

The housing market is characterized by a sharp decline in building permits, down -35.64% YoY, indicating a contraction in housing supply that could lead to future affordability stress. Homes are taking an average of 82 days to sell, a 10.8% YoY increase in days on market, suggesting demand erosion rather than a healthy normalization. The presence of an above-average professional workforce, ranking in the 65th percentile, offers some positive counterbalance, but it is not enough to offset broader economic concerns.

Orlando presents a labor market with some hiring flexibility, but the primary risk is demand erosion and affordability stress in the housing market. Stagnant wage growth and declining building permits pose significant caveats for businesses considering relocation, as they may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers due to limited housing supply and weakened consumer demand.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

C-

CRITICAL

29.3th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

64.5%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

+86.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

30 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

San Francisco's economic landscape is marked by stagnant job growth, sluggish wage increases, and a remarkably high cost of living, with nonfarm employment growth contracting by 0.52% year-over-year and wage growth barely inching up by 0.49%. This labor market weakness is further exacerbated by a cost of living composite score of 5.62, making it one of the most expensive metros in the country, which can significantly constrain talent acquisition and real consumer spending power.

The housing market is experiencing a surge in building permits, with an 86.01% year-over-year increase, which could potentially alleviate some of the affordability pressures in the long term. However, homes are selling extremely quickly, with an average of 30 days on market, creating a competitive and challenging environment for relocating workers.

San Francisco offers a highly skilled but expensive workforce, with significant challenges in terms of talent attraction and retention due to its high cost of living. The primary risk for businesses considering locating in San Francisco is the potential for weakened consumer demand and labor market slack, which could undermine the viability of certain business models.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

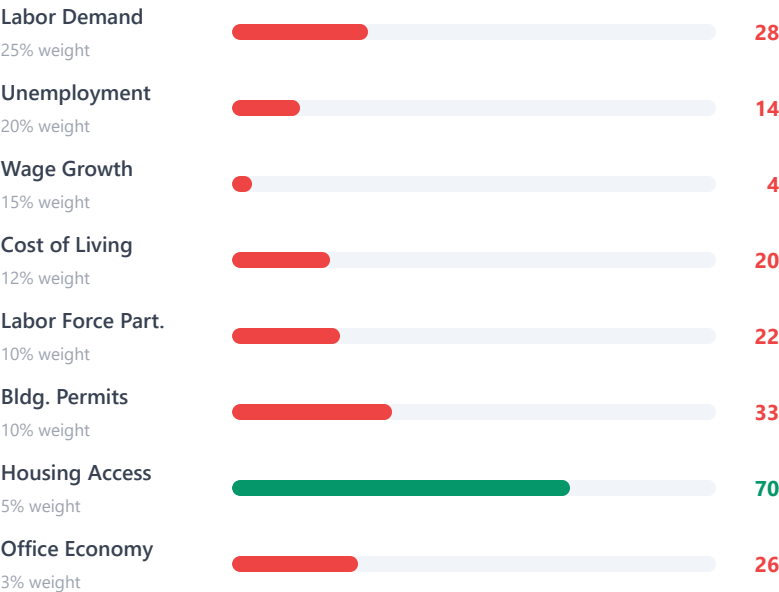
D

EMERGENCY

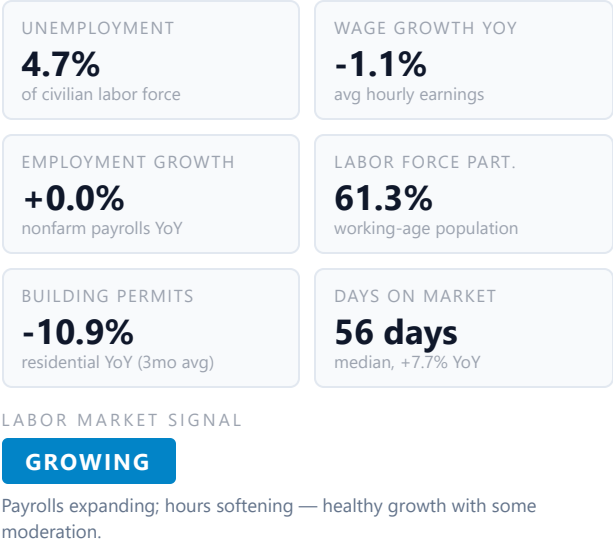
22.6th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Detroit's economy earns a dismal grade of D, ranking 22.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor market characterized by severe weakness. The unemployment rate stands at 4.70%, and wage growth has stagnated at -1.13% year-over-year. The labor force participation rate of 61.27% indicates a shallow labor pool, suggesting an aging workforce or withdrawal from the job market.

The data reveals tensions between the cost of living and the housing market. Despite a below-average cost of living composite score of 4.06, the days on market have increased by 7.7% year-over-year, with homes taking an average of 56 days to sell. This suggests a slowing housing market, which may be a sign of demand erosion, given the weak employment growth of +0.01% year-over-year and declining building permits of -10.94%.

Detroit's labor market weakness poses significant risks, constraining consumer spending and limiting access to skilled talent. The slowing housing market and declining building permits exacerbate these risks, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider the potential challenges of operating in this market.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

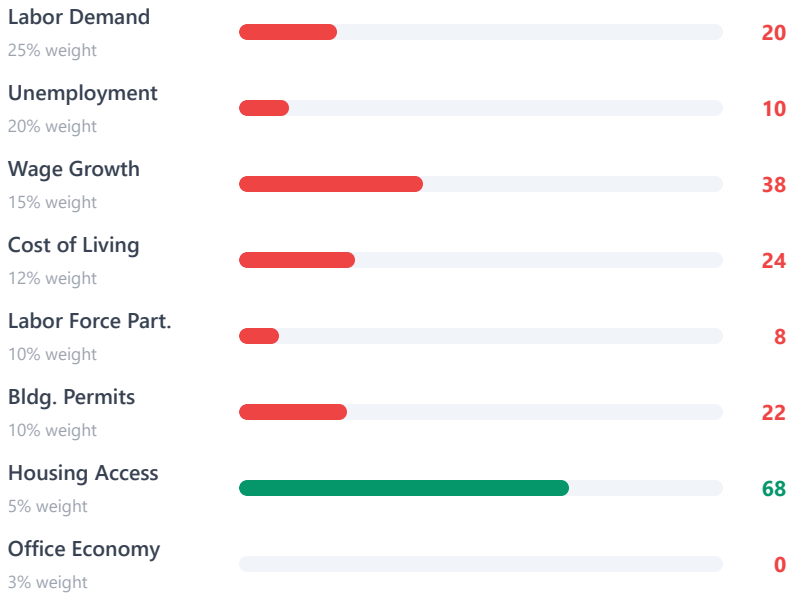
D

EMERGENCY

22.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE PART.

60.1%

working-age population

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.5%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

41 days

median, +5.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area earns a dismal D grade, ranking 22nd out of 50 US metros, driven by severe labor market weakness. The city's unemployment rate stands at 4.80%, with a critically low labor force participation rate of 60.12%. This paints a picture of a struggling labor market, posing significant risks to consumer spending and business growth.

The data reveals tensions between different metrics. While the cost of living composite is 3.72, indicating a below-average cost of living, the low concentration of professional and office workers, ranking in the 0th percentile, poses a significant constraint for knowledge-economy businesses. The housing market is also showing signs of slowing, with days on market increasing by 5.1% year-over-year to an average of 41 days, indicating softening demand.

The bottom line is that Sacramento offers a low-cost environment, but this is outweighed by significant labor market and workforce constraints. The primary risk for businesses considering relocation to this city is the potential for weak economic growth and limited access to skilled workers, hindering their ability to expand and thrive.